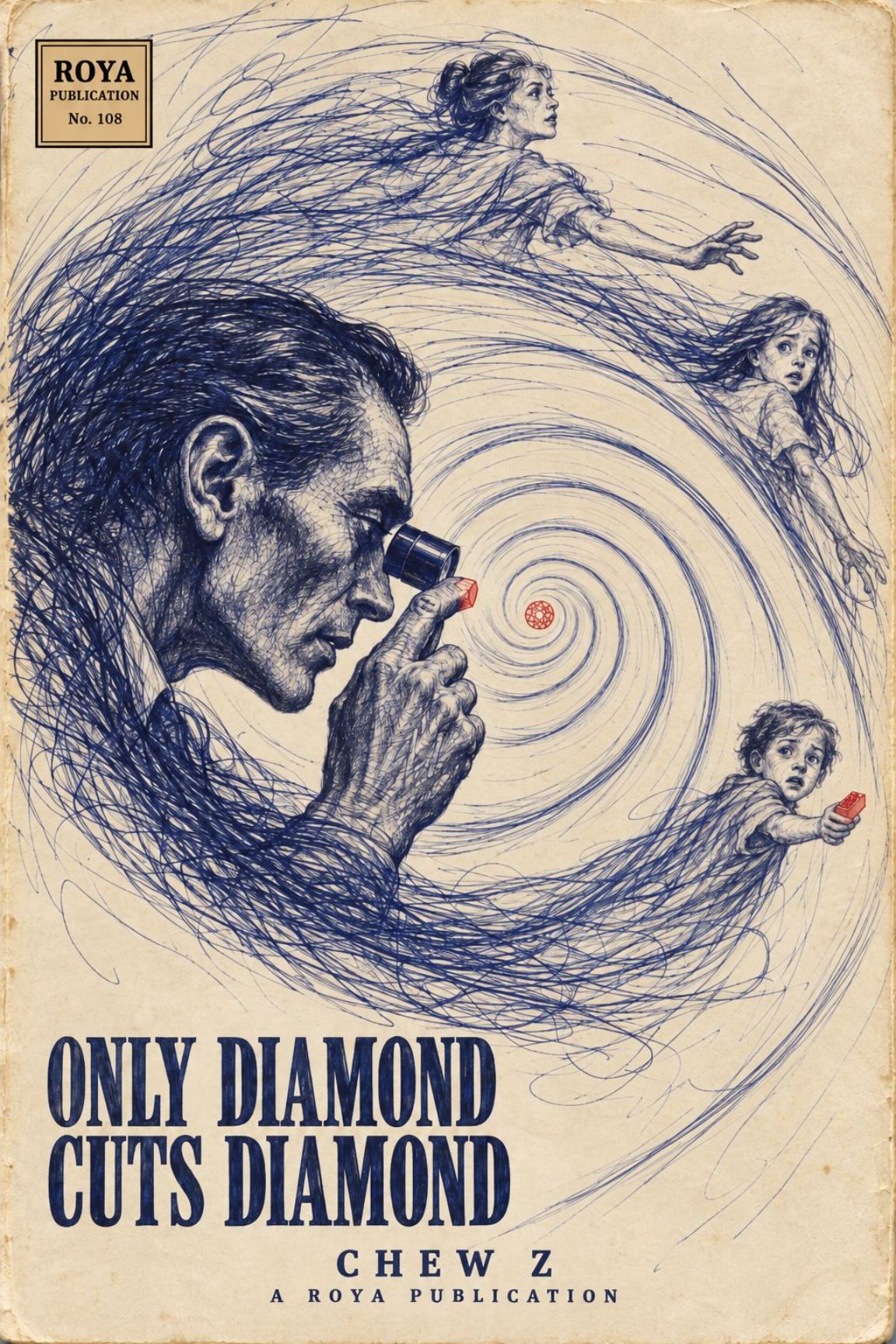


**ROYA**

PUBLICATION

No. 108



# ONLY DIAMOND CUTS DIAMOND

**C H E W   Z**

A ROYA PUBLICATION

# **ONLY DIAMOND CUTS DIAMOND**

CHEW Z

Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 108

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

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## SYNOPSIS

Kian Sarrāf has an engine in him. He has had it since he was four, counting tiles in a Tehran basement while the bombs fell. Something catches his eye, the world goes quiet around it, and he does not come back until he has mastered it. A Rubik's cube. Chess. A trading firm worth more than his father ever dreamed of. A 1967 Porsche rebuilt from three thousand bags of bolts.

His wife Roxana calls them his seasons. She writes each one on the calendar on the fridge, and when it ends she writes two words: *Welcome back*. For sixteen years he always comes back, to her, to their daughter Sahar, to their son Kaveh, to a long low house in a Los Angeles canyon that smells of hot clay on firing days.

Then, on the night he finishes the car, there is a curve on a mountain road.

Grief gives the engine nothing to hold. Until, at three in the morning, Kian learns that a laboratory can grow a diamond from what is left of a person. He decides that nobody will cut it but him. He leaves his children with his mother and goes to Antwerp, to the last hand-cutter on a street of armed guards and steel posts: Elias Karam, eighty years old, born in the diamond fields of Sierra Leone, who answers the last of thirty-one letters with four words.

*Come. Bring nothing. E.*

Elias teaches him the oldest rule of the trade. Every stone carries one tension. Find it before you cut, or it finds you.

Kian thinks he knows where his is.

## A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

*A warning first. This book contains graphic descriptions of cremation and of human remains, serious injury, the violence of a real war, and the grief of children. It does not offer comfort at the end. If you are carrying a fresh loss, it may be kinder to wait.*

I have an engine in me. I don't know when it started. I only know that it has always been running.

It works like this. Something catches my eye: a question, a skill, an old object, a problem nobody has solved. Then the world goes quiet. Everything that is not that one thing fades to grey. Sleep becomes optional. Food becomes fuel. Hours disappear and I don't miss them. For a while, I am the happiest person alive.

Then I master it, or close enough. The engine has nothing left to chew. And the quiet I loved turns into a different kind of quiet, empty and loud at the same time. I have learned to dread that silence more than any failure. So the engine goes looking for the next thing. It always finds one.

People who live like this don't choose it. I have come to believe it is closer to a temperament than a decision, the way some people are born tall. It has given me nearly everything I am proud of. It has also cost things I can't count, because I was never looking at that ledger. Someone else was keeping it.

That is what this book is about. Not the obsession itself, which is easy to admire, but the people standing just outside it.

What I wanted to understand, and wanted the reader to feel, is how an obsessed mind actually thinks. Not as an illness or a superpower, but from the inside. How the people you love start to sound like interruptions. How "good enough" sounds like a lie. How you can love your family completely and still not hear what they are saying, because part of you is somewhere else, turning a stone over in the light.

And I wanted to turn the camera round. What does it feel like to be the wife who keeps the calendar of someone else's seasons? The

child who waits at the edge of a room for a parent to come back from a place they can't follow? The people who love an obsessive are often the most patient people in the world, and their patience is rarely seen, because the one person who should notice it is busy.

The diamond seemed the right stone for this story. It is the hardest natural thing we know. Only another diamond can cut it. That felt true of obsession too. Only someone who has the engine can fully understand someone else who has it, and that understanding can be a comfort or a trap. Diamonds also carry a long human history of wanting: kings who killed for them, a slogan that taught the whole planet to desire them, a war paid for with them. Obsession is not a private flaw. It is one of the oldest things we do as a species.

The diamond trade, its methods and its history are real. The civil war in Sierra Leone and the mutilation of its civilians are real. Memorial diamonds made from a person's ashes are real, and can be ordered today. Grief hallucinations, seeing or hearing someone who has died, are common and well recorded. The people in this book are invented, and so is the one turn the plot hangs on. I won't say which, but you will know it when you reach it.

I don't know whether the engine can be turned off. I am no longer sure I would want it to be. But I know now that it can be pointed. It can be aimed at a stone, or at a person. The second is much harder, because a person doesn't hold still under the loupe, and is never finished, and was never meant to be.

Chew Z

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## **I. ROUGH**

## The Little Engine

My name is Kian Sarrāf [kee-YAAN sar-RAAF]. The first thing I can remember is counting.

I was four years old and we were in the basement of our building in Tehran, because the city was being bombed. This was during the war with Iraq, which began the year before I was born and lasted until I was seven, so for most of my childhood the war was simply the weather. That spring, Iraqi planes came over the city at night. Most nights nothing happened. Some nights the radio stopped whatever it was playing and a man's voice said, *Attention, attention. The signal you are about to hear is the danger signal. It means an air raid. Leave your place of work or your home and go to a shelter.* Then the siren went up over the rooftops, a long rising wail, and the radio called it *vaz'iyat-e ghermez* [vaz-ee-YAT-e gher-MEZ], *the red situation*. Every family in the building went down the stairs with blankets and a flask of tea and sat in the dark until the radio said the other words, *vaz'iyat-e sefid* [vaz-ee-YAT-e se-FEED], *the white situation*, which meant it was over.

The basement floor was laid in square tiles. I counted them. There were sixty-four between the boiler and the far wall, eight rows of eight. I counted them forward and backward. I counted the cracks in them. When the siren started I counted the seconds until the first sound of an impact, and when it came I started again from zero and counted until the next one.

My mother sat with her back against the wall and held me in her lap. She noticed that while I was counting I did not cry. She also noticed that the other children did.

"His little engine is running," she told my father. She said it in Persian, *motor-e kuchik* [mo-TOR-e koo-CHEEK], and she said it the way you might talk about a dog that will not stop digging in the garden. With love, and a little bit of worry.

Here is the first thing I ever learned about my own mind, and I learned it before I could read. When it had one thing to hold, it stopped being afraid. It did not matter what the thing was. Tiles. Seconds. The number of times the man in the corner coughed. If I

gave my mind one thing and nothing else, the whole loud world went quiet around it, and inside that quiet I was safe.

I have spent the rest of my life looking for that quiet. Everything in this book follows from it.

My father mended carpets.

Not new carpets. Old ones, hand-knotted, eighty and a hundred years old, from Kashan and Tabriz and the tribes in the south. People brought them to him torn, moth-eaten, burned by a dropped coal, chewed by a dog. He laid them face down on a long table in the back room of his shop and studied them through a magnifying glass, the way a doctor studies an X-ray. Then he rebuilt them, one knot at a time.

A good Persian carpet can have more than three hundred knots in a single square inch. My father would sit with one square inch for an entire day. He matched the wool to the old colours by eye, dyed it himself in pots on a gas ring, and tied each knot by hand with a hook no longer than his little finger. When he was finished you could not find the place where the damage had been. I used to try. I would run my hands over the carpet with my eyes closed, feeling for the scar, and never find it.

"A carpet forgives nothing and forgets nothing," he told me. "So you do not make mistakes. You go slowly enough that there are none."

On Fridays, when the shop was closed, he let me sit beside him and hand him the threads. He would name a colour, *madder red*, from the root of a plant, *walnut brown*, *the blue that is almost black*, and I would find it in the basket and lay it in his palm. If I chose wrong he did not scold me. He held the thread up to the window, held it beside the carpet, and waited for me to see the difference myself.

I always did, eventually. I would stare until I saw it.

My father never told me to stop staring. I think now that he was the only person in my life who never did. He had an engine too. His just ran slower than mine.

The worst of it came when I was six.

People who were in Tehran that year still call it *the war of the cities*. At the end of winter, Iraq stopped sending planes and started sending missiles: long-range rockets fired from far across the border, each one carrying a warhead about the weight of a motorbike. Over fifty-two days that spring, more than a hundred of them came down on Tehran. They fell by day and by night. They fell on neighbourhoods, markets and apartment blocks, because they were not aimed at anything smaller than the city.

A missile is different from a plane, and every child in Tehran learned the difference in a week. You could hear a plane coming. The siren had time to wail, the radio had time to say its sentence, and you had time to get down the stairs. A missile came faster than any of that. Sometimes the siren started after the explosion. Sometimes there was no siren at all, only a flat crack that shook the windows in their frames, and then, a few seconds later, every dog in the district barking at once.

So we stopped going upstairs. For most of that spring we lived in the basement. Forty people from eleven flats slept on the tiles, on carpets my father brought down from the shop, with our clothes on and our shoes beside our heads. The schools closed. The bakeries opened at dawn and were sold out by seven. Anyone who had a car, or a cousin in a village, or a sister near the Caspian Sea, left. By the middle of spring our street was half empty, and people said a quarter of the whole city had gone. Nobody knew the real number. There was nobody left to count.

Except me. I counted.

I kept a school exercise book under my pillow in the basement. Every time I heard an impact I made a mark in it, with the time, if I could see the boiler-room clock, and a word for how it sounded: *far, near, very near, the windows*. When the radio read out where a missile had landed, I wrote the name of the district beside the mark. When the radio gave a number of dead, I wrote the number in the margin and added it to the total at the top of the page.

I did not think of the numbers as people. I want to be honest about that, because it is the first time it happened and it was not the last.

They were numbers, and numbers were safe, and the total at the top of the page went up every day like a score. Keeping it tidy made me feel that someone, somewhere, was in charge.

One night, very near, a missile came down three streets away. The basement shook and white dust sifted down from the ceiling onto the blankets. A woman screamed. The baby from the third floor began to cry and did not stop for an hour. My mother pulled me against her so hard I could feel her heart going against my back, fast and hard, like something trying to get out.

"Hold my hand," she whispered. "Kian. Hold my hand."

I didn't. I needed my hand to make the mark.

She took the exercise book from me in the morning, while I was still asleep. I woke to see her sitting on the bottom step in the grey light with it open on her knees, turning the pages slowly. She had reached the total at the top of the last page. Her lips were moving. She was reading it the way you read a name on a gravestone.

She did not scold me. She closed the book, and put it back under my pillow, and went upstairs to see if there was bread. But she did not call me *her little engine* again for a long time, and when she did, years later, she no longer said it as a joke.

That spring my father did not close his shop. He said that the carpets did not know there was a war. Every morning he walked the eleven streets to the bazaar and sat at his long table under the bare bulb, re-knotting a Kashan with a burn hole in it the size of a fist, while the windows rattled in their frames. He took me with him twice, when my mother was too tired to argue. I sat under the table and handed him threads.

Once, a missile came down close enough that the bulb swung on its wire and the shadows of the table legs swung with it, back and forth across the floor. My father's hook stopped for a moment above the knot. Then he finished the knot.

"How far?" I asked him. I wanted it for the book.

He looked at me under the table for a long time.

"Ask me how many," he said. "Not how far. How many."

I didn't understand him. I said, "How many?"

"Too many," he said, and tied the next knot.

The missiles stopped in the spring. The war stopped that summer. We left Tehran a few weeks later, the summer I was seven. My father sold the shop and the tools and most of the carpets. He kept one, a small prayer rug with a hole in its corner that he had never got round to fixing. He said he would fix it in America.

He never did. It is on the floor of my front hall now, in Los Angeles, with the hole still in it.

I have thought about that hole more than I have thought about almost anything. A man who could rebuild a hundred-year-old carpet so that nobody could find the scar, and he left one hole open, in his own rug, for thirty years.

I did not understand it until very recently. I will come to it.

## **Westwood**

We lived in two rooms above a dry cleaner on Westwood Boulevard. The street was full of Iranian shops and Iranian restaurants and Iranian men arguing outside the bakery in the mornings, so many that people called the neighbourhood Tehrangeles. My father opened a small repair shop two blocks down. My mother worked the counter at a pharmacy and learned English faster than any of us.

In the first month I sorted my father's threads. He kept them in three old biscuit tins, four hundred skeins of wool all tangled together, and one Saturday while he was out I sorted every one of them by colour, from the palest cream to the blue that is almost black, in a long line across the floor of the shop. It took me six hours. I was very proud.

He came back and looked at it for a while. He said it was beautiful. He left it that way for a week. Then one evening I saw him on his knees, quietly putting them back in his own order, which was not by colour at all. It was by how often he reached for them. The ones he used most were nearest his hand.

He never said a word about it. I understood it about thirty years later.

I did not speak English when I arrived. So I learned it the only way I knew how. I took a paperback dictionary from the library and started at *A*.

I did not learn words. I learned the dictionary. I read it the way other children read comics, under the blanket with a torch. By Christmas I was at *M*. My teacher called my parents in to ask how a boy who had arrived in September was using the word *meretricious*, which means showy and cheap, in a spelling test. My mother did not know what it meant either. She looked at me across the little table with the same face she had worn in the basement, the dog-in-the-garden face, and said nothing all the way home.

When I was nine, a neighbour gave me a Rubik's cube for my birthday.

If you have never held one: it is a plastic cube, a little bigger than a fist, with six faces in six colours, each face divided into nine squares. You twist the rows and the colours scramble. The puzzle is to twist them back.

There are forty-three quintillion ways to scramble it. Forty-three followed by eighteen zeroes. I know because I looked it up that first night, and the number frightened me and delighted me in exactly equal parts.

It took me twenty-nine days to solve it without help.

I did not eat breakfast. I did not hear my mother calling me. I did my homework in the five minutes before class and twisted the cube under the desk with my other hand. I dreamed in colours. I stopped seeing my friends. By the third week I could see the cube with my eyes closed, all six faces at once, the way you can see a room in the dark if you have lived in it long enough.

On the twenty-ninth night, at about eleven o'clock, the last corner turned into place and every face was one colour.

I remember the feeling exactly. It went through me like warm water. It was the best feeling I had ever had in my life, better than Christmas, better than anything, and it lasted about four minutes.

Then it was gone. And something else came in behind it.

I did not have a word for it then. I have one now. I call it **dead air**. It is the phrase radio people use for the silence when a station has nothing to broadcast. That is what it feels like. The engine is still running, but there is nothing in front of it. The quiet I loved, the safe quiet of one thing, turns into a different quiet. It is empty and it is loud at the same time.

I put the cube on my desk. The next day I could not look at it. I could not bear to have it in the room, this thing that had been the whole world for twenty-nine days and was now just a plastic toy. I gave it to a boy in my class. He was very pleased.

My mother found me lying on my bed with my shoes on, staring at the ceiling.

"What's wrong?" she said.

"Nothing."

She sat on the edge of the bed. She did not touch me. She knew better.

"It will find something else," she said. "It always does."

She was right. It always did.

## **Sixty-Four Squares**

At fourteen it found chess.

A teacher set up a board at lunch to teach a few of us the moves. I watched for ten minutes. Then I went to the library and took out every chess book they had, eleven of them, and carried them home in two plastic bags.

The board is eight squares by eight. Sixty-four. The same as the basement floor in Tehran. I did not notice that until years later, and when I did, I had to sit down.

I want to tell you what the next two years were like, because it is the clearest example I have of how my mind works. Years later I gave the stages names, and I will use them now so you can see the shape.

The first stage is **the hook**. Something catches. It is never something I go looking for. It is a door left open in a corridor, and I glance through it, and I am already inside.

The second stage is **the narrowing**. The world begins to shrink. At first it is pleasant, like the lights going down in a cinema. Everything that is not the one thing fades to grey. Food becomes something I do so that I can keep going. Sleep becomes something I do when I can no longer see the board. And people, and this is the part that is hard to say, people become interruptions. I loved my parents. I loved my friends. But when my mother called me for dinner, what I felt was not love. It was the feeling you have when someone talks to you during the best part of a film.

The third stage is **the burn**. This is the part outsiders see and cannot understand. No sleep, no food, sixteen hours a day, and I was not suffering. I was the happiest I have ever been. That is the thing nobody tells you about obsession. From the inside it does not feel like a sickness. It feels like being completely alive.

The fourth stage is **the summit**. Mastery, or something close to it.

The fifth is dead air.

By fifteen I was playing in adult tournaments on weekends. By sixteen my rating was a few points short of the title of master. I played my father in the evenings, on a board I had set on top of one of his repair jobs, a Bakhtiari rug with a garden pattern. He was a terrible player and he never minded. He would watch my face while I thought. I didn't know he was doing it. He told me so much later.

"You looked," he said, "like a man listening for something very far away."

The summer I was sixteen I missed his fiftieth birthday. There was a weekend tournament in San Diego. I had told my mother I would be back for dinner and I was not. I was in the final round, in a position I had studied for a month, and I did not think about my father or his birthday once. I did not think about anything. That was the point.

I won. I came home at midnight with a small trophy and found the cake on the table with fifty candles in it, none of them lit. My father was asleep in his chair. My mother was washing the dishes, slowly,

the way you wash dishes when you want somebody to notice you washing them.

I stood in the doorway holding the trophy. And for the first time in my life I saw the shape of what I had done from the outside. Not the game. The empty chair at the table, kept for me all evening.

I felt ashamed. It was a real shame and it went deep.

And here is the second thing I learned about my mind, and it is uglier than the first. Even standing there ashamed, some part of me was still replaying the final position. Some part of me was checking whether my knight had really been safe on the twenty-third move.

I quit chess two weeks later. Not because of the shame. I quit because I had reached the top of what I could do on my own, and the dead air came in, and the board looked like a piece of painted wood.

I gave the books back to the library. All eleven. They were very overdue.

## **The Firm**

I studied mathematics at UCLA, which surprised nobody. I did very well, which surprised nobody either. I had a handful of friends, and I was not easy to be friends with. I would vanish for a month into a problem set and come out blinking, like a man from a cave, and expect everyone to be exactly where I had left them.

Mostly they were. People are kinder than they need to be.

At twenty-six I started a trading firm with two men I had met in a graduate seminar. I will not tell you their names. They are not part of this story and they would not want to be. What we did, in plain words, was teach computers to notice tiny patterns in the prices of things and to buy and sell faster than any human could. It was a puzzle with real money on the other side of it. It was the Rubik's cube with forty-three quintillion dollars attached.

The hook caught in the first week. The narrowing took about a month. The burn lasted, with short breaks, for eight years.

I worked ninety hours a week. I slept on a couch in the office three or four nights out of seven. My mother learned to call the office number instead of my flat, and to start every call with the words *I know you're busy*, so I would not have to say it. I ate the same lunch every day for two years, a turkey sandwich from the same shop, because choosing lunch was a decision, and I did not want to spend a decision on lunch.

We made money. Then we made more money than I had known existed. In the third year I bought my parents a house in the hills above Encino, with a garden and a lemon tree. My mother cried in the driveway. My father walked through every room, slowly, and then asked if there was space in the garage for a long table.

He kept working. He never stopped. At sixty-five he was still re-knotting other people's carpets in that garage, with the door open for the light, while the lemons dropped in the yard. I offered to pay him to retire. He laughed at me.

"Retire and do what?" he said. "Sit?"

I understood him perfectly. It was the most I ever felt like his son.

I had been running the firm for about a year when I met Roxana.

## **Good Enough**

It was a ceramics show in an old warehouse in Venice, near the beach. A friend had dragged me there. I hated crowds and I didn't care about pottery, and I stood near the door with a plastic cup of wine planning how soon I could leave.

Then I saw the bowl.

It sat by itself on a wooden plinth near the back. It was small, about the size of two cupped hands, and the glaze was a deep grey-blue that went almost black at the rim, like the sea just after sunset. It was not perfectly round. One side rose a little higher than the other, as if the bowl had leaned to listen to something.

I looked at it for a long time. I was looking for the flaw. That is what I do with beautiful things. I look for the place where they went wrong, because if I can find it, I can understand how they were made.

"There's a crack," said a woman beside me. "Inside the foot. You can't see it."

She was about my age. She had clay dried on her forearms, and her hair was tied up with a pencil stuck through it, and she was looking at me with open amusement, the way you look at a man who has been staring at a bowl for six minutes.

"Then how do you know it's there?" I said.

"Because I made it."

She picked the bowl up and turned it over to show me. I still couldn't see anything.

"I'd fix it," I said, before I could stop myself.

"I know you would," she said. "You've got that face." She put the bowl back on its plinth. "But it holds water. It holds soup. It's good enough. That's the best thing a bowl can be."

Good enough. I had never in my life heard those two words put together as praise.

Her name was Roxana [rok-SAA-na]. Her parents had come from Shiraz before the revolution, and she had been born in Los Angeles and spoke Persian with a California accent that my mother would later find unbearably charming. She made bowls and cups and plates in a rented studio in Mar Vista. She made them until they were good enough, and then she stopped, and then she made the next one.

She gave me the bowl. She would not let me pay for it. "You'll just stare at it," she said. "That's better than money."

I have it still. I have never found the crack.

I was a terrible boyfriend. She told me so, cheerfully and often.

I forgot dinners. I disappeared for days into the firm and came out surprised that the weekend had passed. Once, in the first year, I cancelled a trip to Big Sur at four in the morning because a model was misbehaving, and she drove up alone, and sent me a photograph of the sea with no message, and that was the message.

Any other woman would have left. Roxana did something stranger. She studied me.

She studied me the way my father studied a carpet, patiently, without blame, looking for the pattern. And after about a year she found it.

I came home one night at three in the morning. She was sitting up in bed with a sketchbook.

"What season is this?" she said.

"What?"

"You have seasons," she said. "Like weather. I've been watching. Something grabs you and you go away into it, and you're gone for a month, or a year, and you come back thin and happy, and then you're sad for a while, and then something else grabs you. It's a season." She tapped the sketchbook with her pencil. "So which one are we in?"

Nobody had ever seen it that clearly. Not my mother. Not even my father, who saw it but never said it out loud. I sat down on the bed in my coat and could not speak.

The next morning there was a calendar on the fridge. A big paper one, a month to a page. Across the top of October she had written in green marker: *THE MODEL SEASON. Expected end: unknown. Bring snacks.*

She kept it up for sixteen years. Every season got a name and a colour. When one ended she drew a small line across the bottom of the month, and on the next day, without fail, she wrote two words: *Welcome back.*

She never once asked me to be different. That is the thing I want you to understand about her, before anything else in this book. She did not ask me to stop. She asked me to come back between seasons.

And I always did. I always came back.

The one time I tried to buy her a diamond, I made a season of it.

I spent four months learning about diamonds before I proposed. I read everything. The four Cs: cut, colour, clarity, carat. How a round stone is cut with fifty-seven or fifty-eight flat faces, called facets, angled so that light goes in through the top and bounces around inside and comes back out at your eye. I learned that the mathematics of that bounce had been worked out in 1919 by a young engineer named Tolkowsky [tol-KOV-skee]. I learned that a diamond is only carbon, the same element as pencil lead and coal, squeezed for a billion years in the dark.

At a jeweller's in Beverly Hills an old man let me look at a stone through his loupe [LOOP], a little magnifying glass you hold right up to the eye. Inside the diamond, very small, I saw a flaw. It looked like a white feather, frozen in the middle of the stone, as if something had been falling through it when the stone set hard around it.

I looked at that feather for twenty minutes. The jeweller let me. I think he had seen the face before.

Then I bought the stone and asked Roxana to marry me, and she said yes, and then she laughed and said she could not wear a diamond ring in the studio because it would get full of clay and she would lose it in a pot. So she wore it on a thin chain around her neck, for the rest of her life, and she wore a plain gold band on her finger instead.

The diamond season ended the day she said yes. I didn't think about diamonds again for nearly sixteen years.

But I want you to notice something. The hook didn't fail to catch. I remember that feather. I can still see it if I close my eyes. The hook had caught. It was only waiting.

## **The House**

We were married in her parents' garden in the summer. My father wore a suit for the first time since Tehran and danced with every woman in the family. My mother cried, as she did in driveways, at weddings and at good news of any kind.

Halfway through the evening I noticed that the band's violinist was playing very slightly flat, a hair under every note, and once I

noticed, I could not hear anything else. Roxana felt it happen. She always could. She found my hand under the table and pressed it twice, which in the language we had by then meant *not tonight*. I let it go. It was hard, and I did it for her, and I think it was the best wedding present I gave her.

Sahar [sa-HAR] was born the next year. Her name means *dawn*, because she came at ten past five in the morning, after a long night, and the window of the hospital room turned grey and then pink while Roxana held her. Through most of that night I timed her contractions on a stopwatch, to the tenth of a second, and read the numbers out. Around three in the morning she took the stopwatch out of my hand and threw it across the room, and the nurse laughed, and I held Roxana's hand instead. It was the right thing. I had to be shown it.

I am going to tell you how I loved my daughter, because later in this book you will need to remember it.

I loved her so much it frightened me. In her first month I did what I always do with something I love: I tried to understand it completely. I kept a spreadsheet. I logged every feed, every nap, every nappy, and the colour of what was in it. I drew graphs of her sleep. I read eleven books about infant development, the same number as the chess books, which I noticed and did not like.

On the twenty-fourth day Roxana came into my study at three in the morning with Sahar on her shoulder. She looked at the graphs on my screen. Then she closed the laptop, gently, with one hand.

"She isn't a model," she said. "She's a baby. Come and hold her."

I did. Sahar was warm and heavy and smelled of milk, and she fell asleep against my neck with her small fist closed on my collar. I stood in the dark kitchen holding her for an hour. I did not count anything. It was one of the few hours of my life when the engine was simply off.

On the fridge, Roxana wrote: *THE SPREADSHEET SEASON. Ended by force*. Under it she drew a baby with a crown.

Sahar grew up funny. That was the main thing about her. She was funny before she could talk. She had her mother's habit of watching

me with amusement, and by the age of six she had her mother's habit of saying what she saw.

"Baba [baa-BAA] is in a season," she would tell visitors, gravely. "We don't talk to him until it's over."

She read the fridge calendar the way other children read comics. She knew the names of all my seasons. When she was eight she started adding her own captions in pencil under her mother's. Under *THE MIRROR SEASON*, which was the year I spent grinding a telescope mirror by hand in the garage, she wrote: *He talks to it. It does not talk back.*

She was right. I did talk to it.

That was the year she played a tree in her school play. She had one line. I was there, in the third row, and I want that written down, because I was not always there. But I spent most of the play working out in my head the curve I would need to grind into the mirror that night, and when she said her line I was a fraction of a second late looking up. She saw. Children always see. Afterwards, in the car, she asked me what her line had been. I told her. I had heard it. She nodded and looked out of the window and did not ask me anything else.

My father died in the winter of the mirror season, two years after I sold the firm. He was seventy. His heart stopped at his long table in the garage in Encino, with a Tabriz half-mended in front of him and the hook still in his hand.

He did not die at once. There were three hours in the hospital. My mother called me four times. I was in our garage with the phone face down on the workbench, because its buzz shook the mirror, and I had reached the part of the grinding where you cannot stop or the glass is spoiled.

I got there in time. I want that written down too. I arrived forty minutes after everybody else, and he was still awake. He looked at my hands, which were grey to the wrist with glass dust, and he smiled, as if that told him everything about where I had been. He did not seem angry. He seemed to recognise it.

"Did you finish?" he asked.

I said I had.

“Good,” he said. “Then sit.”

I sat with him until the morning. I did not count anything.

I never used the mirror. It is still in its box in the garage.

I sold my share of the firm when I was thirty-four.

I had reached the summit. There was nothing left in it I did not understand, and when I understood it completely, the dead air came in, and the most profitable business I would ever build looked to me like a piece of painted wood.

My partners thought I was mad. Roxana did not. She had seen it coming for months. She had already written on the calendar, in advance, in pencil, *THE FIRM — ending soon?*

What came after was the worst dead air of my life. For four months I did nothing. I sat in the garden. I lay on the floor of my study. I could not read, because reading is a task, and the engine refused any task that was not the right one. I lost weight. I stopped answering the phone. My mother came over and cooked and watched me with her basement face.

Roxana did not try to fix me. She knew it could not be fixed, only waited out. She went to the studio and came home and sat beside me in the garden in the evenings and talked about her day, about a glaze that had run, a kiln that had cracked a whole shelf, a customer who wanted a bowl the exact colour of her dog. She did not need me to answer. She just kept the sound of a life going near me, like a radio left on in a sick room.

That winter Kaveh [kaa-VEH] was born. We named him after the blacksmith in the old Persian *Book of Kings*, the poor man who stood up to a tyrant and raised his leather apron on a spear as a flag.

The night we brought him home, the dead air lifted. It did not go all at once. But I held him in the same dark kitchen where I had held his sister, and I felt the engine start again, slowly, the way a car starts on a cold morning.

Here is our house, in the years before. I want you to see it.

It is a long, low house in the hills of Topanga, at the end of a dirt road, with oak trees and a view down the canyon toward the sea. There is a studio for Roxana at the bottom of the garden, with a kiln in a shed beside it, and on firing days the whole place smells of hot stone. There is a double garage, and the left half of it is mine.

There is a fridge in the kitchen, and on the fridge there is a calendar, and on the calendar are my seasons, in Roxana's handwriting, sixteen years of them, the old ones kept in a box under the stairs.

*THE CHOPIN SEASON*, which was the year I tried to learn one piano étude [ay-TOOD], a study piece, a fast, cruel one Chopin wrote at nineteen, and practised it six hours a day until my wrists ached and I could play it at the speed he asked for, once, on a Tuesday afternoon with nobody listening. Then never again.

*THE BREAD SEASON*, which was short and which everyone enjoyed.

*THE MIRROR SEASON. THE LATIN SEASON. THE SEASON OF THE BEES*, which ended badly, with the bees.

And the long one, the one that was running in the summer this story turns. *THE CAR*.

Nowruz [now-ROOZ] is the Persian New Year. It falls on the first day of spring. Every Iranian family lays a table for it, called the *haft-sin* [haft-SEEN], with seven things on it whose names begin with the Persian letter S: wheat sprouts for new life, garlic for health, apples for beauty, and so on. There is a mirror, and a bowl with a goldfish in it, and painted eggs.

Our last Nowruz together, my mother came up the canyon with a tray of sweets and the gold tea spoon she had carried out of Tehran in her handbag. It was the only gold thing she brought. She set it beside the mirror on the haft-sin every year, polished, because it had been her own mother's.

Sahar was nearly fifteen that spring. She painted the eggs and wrote rude words on them in tiny letters, and then turned the rude

sides to face the wall so her grandmother would not see. Her grandmother saw. Her grandmother laughed so hard she had to sit down.

Kaveh was nine. He did not paint eggs. He was busy.

Kaveh had sorted all his Lego by colour into ice-cube trays. He had borrowed every ice-cube tray in the house, and two from the neighbours, and lined them up across the living-room floor: red, orange, yellow, green, the three different blues, and the grey that Lego calls *dark bluish grey* and that he insisted on calling by its full name. He was not building anything. He was sorting. He had been sorting for three days.

At some point Sahar, passing, picked a red brick out of the red tray and dropped it into the yellow one as a joke.

Kaveh screamed. Not a tantrum scream. A scream of real pain, as if she had stepped on his hand. He found the brick, put it back, and then checked every tray on the floor, one by one, with his lips moving, until he was sure nothing else was wrong.

Sahar stood there frozen, holding her paintbrush. She looked across the room at me. I will never forget that look. She was not asking me what was wrong with her brother. She was asking me whether I knew.

I knew. I stood in the kitchen doorway and I watched my son count his trays with his lips moving. I felt pride, a fierce warm pride, because I saw myself in him. And under the pride I felt something cold. It was the feeling of watching someone you love walk toward a door you know very well.

Roxana came up beside me, wiping clay off her hands.

"He's yours," she said softly. She did not sound worried. She sounded like a woman reading the weather. "We'll keep an eye on it."

That night I read to him at bedtime. He liked me to read the chess books aloud in voices. I had a voice for every piece. The bishop was a grumpy old man who could only walk diagonally and complained about it constantly. The knight was a show-off who jumped over everyone. The pawns were nervous.

"Do the bishop," Kaveh said.

"I can only go slantways," I said, in the bishop's voice. "My whole life. Slantways. Forty years of slantways. Do you know what that does to a man's knees?"

Kaveh laughed until he got the hiccups. I sat by his bed until he fell asleep, with his hand still curled around a single red brick he had taken to bed with him, to keep it safe.

In the summer Sahar taught Kaveh to swim at Zuma beach.

She had learned there herself, at five, with Roxana holding her flat on the surface of the water and walking her slowly out past the breakers. Now she did the same for her brother. She was strict and patient and she shouted at him in the voice of a gym teacher, and he did everything she said, because she was his sister and fifteen, and because, I think, he worshipped her.

Roxana and I sat on a towel and watched. Or Roxana watched. I was on my phone, reading a forum thread about valve springs for an air-cooled engine built in 1967.

"Kian," she said. "Look at them."

I looked. They were a long way out. Sahar was holding Kaveh flat on the water, the way her mother had held her. The sun was going down behind them and the sea had turned that grey-blue that goes almost black, the colour of the bowl.

"When I go," Roxana said, "I want to go out there. Past the kelp. Where she learned to swim."

"Mm," I said.

I was reading about valve springs. I heard her. I heard the words. I did not take them in. That is the honest truth and I am putting it here because I promised myself, when I began to write this, that I would put the honest truth everywhere I could find it.

"Mm," I said. And went on reading.

She didn't repeat it. She didn't need to. She had said it to the sea, not to me, and the sea was listening.

## First Drive

The car was a 1967 Porsche 911, red, the colour the factory called Polo Red. I bought it from a man in Bakersfield for almost nothing. It had sat in a field for twenty years. There were mice living in the seats and a tree growing through the floor of the boot.

I took it apart in the left half of our garage. Every bolt. I photographed each one before I removed it, labelled it, and stored it in a numbered bag. There were three thousand, one hundred and sixty bags. They hung from wires across the ceiling of the garage like a strange harvest, and when the wind blew down the canyon they turned slowly and clicked against each other.

It took me three years.

I rebuilt the engine by hand. I rebuilt the gearbox. I learned to weld. I learned to shape metal with a hammer over a leather bag of sand. I tracked down original parts in Germany, in Japan, in a widow's barn in Ohio. I learned more about that car than the men who designed it had ever needed to know.

Roxana wrote *THE CAR* across the top of the calendar in red marker, the first season she had ever written in red, and under it she drew a small car with a question mark for a driver.

"Who's going to drive it first?" she said. "When it's done."

"Me," I said.

"We'll see," she said.

Sahar asked me the same question that summer, in a different way. She was fifteen and about to get her learner's permit, and she came into the garage one evening and stood watching me set the valves.

"Can I learn on it?" she said. "When it's finished?"

"Nobody drives it but me," I said, without looking up. "Not even your mother."

I said it lightly. I meant it as a joke about how careful I was. She didn't laugh. She stood there a moment longer, then went back into the house, and I heard her tell Kaveh, in the kitchen, in a voice I was not supposed to hear, *don't bother asking*.

I noticed that. I put it in the part of my mind where I keep things to deal with after the season ends. That part of my mind is very full. Things go in and they do not come out.

I finished it on a night in early September.

I had been awake for about forty hours. That was not unusual at the end of a season. The last stretch is always the worst and the best: the summit in sight, everything narrowed to a single point, the body forgotten. I had been fitting the last trim pieces since the morning before. My eyes were sore. My hands had stopped feeling like mine. None of it mattered.

At two in the morning I took the last bolt out of the last bag, and fitted it, and turned the key.

The engine caught on the first try. It made a sound I cannot describe properly. An air-cooled flat-six has a voice like nothing else, a dry rising snarl, and it filled the garage and rang off the walls and set every one of the three thousand empty bags spinning on its wire.

I sat in the driver's seat with my hands on the wheel and I laughed. I could not stop.

Then the side door opened, and Roxana came into the garage in my old university sweatshirt, barefoot, her hair down, laughing too.

"You did it," she said. "You actually did it."

She walked all the way around the car slowly, the way my father had walked through the new house. She ran her hand along the curve of the roof. Upstairs, through the little garage window, I could see the light in Sahar's bedroom. She was awake. She was always awake at two in the morning that summer, on her phone, the way fifteen-year-olds are.

"Take me for a drive," Roxana said.

"It's two in the morning."

"That's the best time," she said. "Nobody on the roads. Up the Crest. Come on. The kids are asleep. Well, one of them."

I should tell you how it went next, and I am going to tell it the way I remember it.

She wanted to drive it first. She had always said she would, and now she said it again, standing by the door in her bare feet, holding her hand out. I remember the keys in her hand. I remember her climbing into the driver's seat and pulling it forward, because she was shorter than me, and laughing at how low the seat was, and saying that it smelled like my garage, which was true.

We drove down the canyon and across the sleeping city and then up into the San Gabriel mountains on the Angeles Crest Highway, the long, empty, twisting road that climbs above Los Angeles into the pines. The Crest road, everyone calls it. At that hour there was nothing on it. The whole city lay below us, an enormous field of orange lights going all the way to the sea, and above us the stars came out one by one as the city's glow fell away.

She put her arm out of the window and let the cold air push against her hand. She was singing something under her breath. I don't remember what. I have tried and I cannot.

I remember being happy. I remember that very clearly. The summit, and the woman I loved beside me, and the car I had built out of three thousand bags of nothing, singing its dry high song through the mountains. If I could choose one minute of my life to keep, I would keep one of those minutes. I would not even need to know which.

Then there was a curve.

I don't remember the curve itself. I remember the headlights sweeping across a wall of rock, and then sweeping across nothing, and then nothing.

I woke in a hospital in Pasadena. My left wrist was broken in two places. There was a long bruise across my chest from the seat belt, going from my left shoulder down to my right hip, like a sash. My face was cut. A doctor told me that I had been very lucky.

He told me other things too. He said them gently and slowly and more than once. I don't remember the words. I remember the shape

of the room while he said them, and a television in the corner with the sound off, showing the weather.

Later the doctor came back alone to look at my wrist. He turned it over in his hands and studied the X-ray against the window.

"This kind of break," he said, not really to me. "You usually see it when someone's holding on to something hard. Bracing."

I said I must have been holding the door handle.

He nodded and wrote something down.

A highway patrol officer came the next afternoon. He was young and polite and he sat on the visitor's chair with his hat on his knees, and he asked me what I remembered.

I told him. I told him she had wanted to drive it first. I told him about the keys in her hand, and her laughing at the low seat, and her arm out of the window in the cold.

He listened. He wrote something in his notebook. He did not look at me while he wrote it. Then he thanked me and stood up and put his hat on and said he was very sorry for my loss.

My mother was standing at the window. She did not turn around the whole time he was there.

That was the last season Roxana wrote on the calendar.

When I came home from the hospital a week later, with my arm in a cast and my mother holding the door, I went into the kitchen and looked at it. *THE CAR*, in red marker, and the little drawing of the car with the question mark in the driver's seat.

There was no line across the bottom of the month. There was no *Welcome back*.

There was nobody left to write it.

## **The Valley of Diamonds**

*This is an old story. It is told in The Thousand and One Nights, in the second voyage of the sailor Sindbad, and it is older than the book that holds it.*

*Sindbad was a merchant of Baghdad who could not stay home. Every time he made his fortune he swore he would never go to sea again, and every time, within a year, the wanting came back, and he went down to the harbour and found a ship.*

*On his second voyage he fell asleep on an island and woke to find the ship gone without him. He wandered until he came to the edge of a great valley with walls so steep no man could climb them. The floor of the valley glittered. It was covered in diamonds, more than he had ever seen, more than any king had ever owned, lying loose on the ground like gravel after rain. And among the diamonds, sleeping in the heat, lay serpents as long as palm trees.*

*No man could go down into that valley and come out again. But the merchants of the country had found a way.*

*They would kill a sheep, skin it, and throw the raw meat from the top of the cliff. It fell among the diamonds, and the wet meat picked them up, the way bread picks up crumbs. Then the great eagles of the mountains would see the meat, and dive, and carry it up to their nests on the cliff top to eat. And the merchants would rush at the nests, shouting and banging pots, and the frightened eagles would fly off, and the merchants would pick the diamonds out of the meat.*

*That is how diamonds were harvested in that country. By feeding something hungry. By waiting for the hunger to lift the stones out of a place no person could reach.*

*Sindbad watched this. And then Sindbad did a thing no merchant had ever thought of. He filled his pockets and his belt and his turban with the largest diamonds he could find. He took a piece of the thrown meat and tied it to his own back with his sash. And he lay down on the floor of the valley among the serpents, and he waited.*

*An eagle came. It took the meat in its claws, and the man with it, and carried them both up out of the valley.*

*The story says he became the richest man in Baghdad. The story says he went home and swore, again, never to go to sea.*

*The story does not say how it felt to lie very still among the serpents, tied to the meat, waiting to be taken by something hungry, and to call that a plan.*

## **II. PLANNING**

## The Retort

Roxana had never wanted a grave.

She told me so once, years before, when we drove past a cemetery in the Valley with rows of flat bronze plaques set into the lawn like tiles. "All that grass," she said, "and nobody can sit on it." She said she wanted to be burned and given back to the sea. I said *mm*. I was in a season. It is in the same part of my mind as the beach at Zuma, the part where things go in and do not come out.

Her parents had raised her without religion. Mine had not, and in the faith my mother grew up in, the body is washed and wrapped and buried in the ground before the next sunset, and it is never burned. My mother said nothing about it. She went into the bathroom and ran the tap so we would not hear her, and came out with her face washed, and said that Roxana's wishes were Roxana's wishes, and that was the end of it.

It was not the end of it for her. I know that now.

The crematorium was in an industrial street in the Valley, between a tyre shop and a company that rented out portable toilets. It was a low building with a car park in front and a small garden of white gravel and one olive tree. You would drive past it a hundred times and never know.

In California the family is allowed to watch. I did not know that until the funeral director asked us, in a quiet room with a box of tissues on every table, whether we would like to be present for what he called *the committal*. He said some families found it helped. Some found it did not.

I said yes before anybody else could answer.

I want to be honest about why. Some of it was love. Some of it was that I could not bear the idea of her going into a room I was not allowed to see. And some of it, I am sorry to say, was the other thing. I wanted to see how it was done.

There is a window. That is the first thing to understand. The family stands in a small room painted the colour of milky coffee, with a few

chairs nobody sits in, and a long window in one wall, and on the other side of the window is the machine.

It is called a retort. I learned that word that morning and I have not been able to forget it. It is a word from old chemistry, for the glass vessel an alchemist heated over a flame. This one was not glass. It was a steel box the size of a small car, lined inside with firebrick, with a heavy door at one end that lifted straight up like a guillotine. It was painted a dull cream, and someone had stuck a small plastic plant on the top of it, and I thought about that plant for a long time afterwards. Someone who worked there every day had thought the machine looked lonely.

Roxana came in on a steel trolley. She was not in a coffin. She was in a plain box of thick cardboard, because she had said once, laughing, that it was a crime to burn good wood. Her name was written on the end of it in black marker, in capital letters, in a stranger's hand.

My mother made a small sound when she saw the marker.

The operator was a big quiet man of about sixty, in a grey work shirt. He looked through the window at us, and nodded once, the way you nod to someone across a room at a funeral. Then he pressed a button, and the door of the retort rose.

I could see the inside. The bricks glowed a deep, dark orange, like the inside of Roxana's kiln on the second day of a firing. The heat came through the glass. It was not much, but you could feel it on your face, the way you feel a fire in another room.

Sahar was standing in front of Kaveh. She had both her hands over his eyes. He did not fight her. He stood very still with his sister's hands on his face, and I could see his lips moving under her fingers. He was counting. I knew he was counting. I did not know what.

The operator slid the box in. It went smoothly, on rollers. The door came down.

For a moment nothing happened. Then there was a sound, low and steady, like wind in a chimney, as the burners lit. It went on and on.

I asked the operator, afterwards, how hot it got.

My mother was in the car with the children. I had gone back in alone, saying I had left my sunglasses, and I found him in a corridor behind the window room, drinking coffee from a paper cup. He did not seem surprised to see me. I think he had seen men like me before.

"About sixteen, seventeen hundred," he said. "Fahrenheit. A bit over nine hundred in Celsius."

"How long?"

"Two hours. Bit more. Depends on the person."

"What's left?"

He looked at me then. Not unkindly. He looked at me the way the jeweller in Beverly Hills had looked at me over the loupe, sixteen years before.

"Bone," he said. "That's all that's left, in the end. The rest goes up the stack. The bone we let cool, and then it goes in a processor, and it comes out like coarse sand. Grey and white. That's what you get back. Four, five pounds, for a grown woman."

"Not ash?"

"People call it ash. It's bone." He drank his coffee. "Everything soft burns. Everything soft is carbon and water, mostly. It goes up into the air. What you get back is what was holding her up."

I stood in the corridor and wrote down what he had said in the notes on my phone. Every word. *Carbon. Goes up the stack. What was holding her up.*

I knew, even then, that this was not normal. I knew a man whose wife had just gone into a furnace should not be standing in a corridor taking notes. I did it anyway. My hand needed something to do. It was the basement again, the exercise book under the pillow, the total at the top of the page. I was making a mark.

When I got back to the car my mother looked at my face, and then at the phone in my hand, and did not ask about the sunglasses.

They gave her back to us four days later in a black plastic box with a label on the lid. Inside was a clear plastic bag, sealed with a metal tie, and inside the bag was Roxana.

The operator had been right. It did not look like ash. It looked like the coarse grey sand at the bottom of a fish tank, with small pale pieces in it, like broken shell. It weighed a little over four pounds. I know because I weighed it on the kitchen scale, the same scale she had used to weigh glaze. Sahar watched me do it from the doorway, and then turned and went upstairs, and I heard her door close very quietly. She had learned from her grandmother how to close a door so that the quiet was louder than a slam.

We put the box on the shelf in the living room, beside the grey-blue bowl. Nobody suggested it. It went there by itself, the way furniture finds its place in a new house.

## **No Task**

Grief, it turns out, has nothing for you to do.

I had expected it to be a kind of work. I thought it would be like dead air, only heavier, and I had lived through dead air a dozen times. I thought I knew its shape. You lie on the floor. You wait. Eventually something catches, and the engine starts, and you are saved.

But grief is not dead air. In dead air the engine has nothing in front of it. In grief, the thing in front of it is a hole, and the engine runs straight into the hole, over and over, all day and all night, because the hole is the only thing there. You keep reaching for a task, and there is no task. There is no problem to solve. There is nothing to learn. She is not hidden somewhere. She is not a puzzle. She is gone, and *gone* has no moving parts.

I tried. God knows I tried. In the first week I got out eleven books about grief, the same number again, noticed, and stopped at seven. I read the research on how long the worst part lasts. I made a spreadsheet of the paperwork: the death certificate, the bank, the insurance, her studio lease, the gallery that still had nine of her bowls on consignment. I finished the spreadsheet in an afternoon. Then there was nothing left on it.

My wrist was in a cast. I could not work in the garage. I would not have gone in there anyway. The car was gone. The insurance company had taken what was left of it on the back of a truck. The three thousand empty bags were still hanging from the ceiling on their wires, and when the canyon wind came through the side door they turned and clicked against each other. I kept the side door shut.

My mother moved into the spare room. She did not ask. She arrived on the second day with a suitcase and a bag of groceries and her gold tea spoon wrapped in a napkin in her handbag, the way she had carried it out of Tehran, and she simply stayed.

She cooked. She drove Kaveh to school, and picked him up, and sat with him at the kitchen table while he did his homework, which he did very slowly and very neatly, rubbing out any letter that was not perfect until he wore holes in the paper. She did the laundry. She sorted Roxana's clothes into three piles on the bed: for the family, for charity, for later. She left the third pile alone.

She watched me. She did not say much. She had her basement face on, all day, every day.

Sahar went back to school after a week. She went because she wanted to be out of the house, and I understood that, and did not stop her. She came home and went to her room. She ate dinner with us and talked to her grandmother and to her brother, and answered me when I spoke to her, politely, in short sentences, the way you answer a teacher you do not like.

I knew something was wrong between us. I could not see what it was. I put it in the part of my mind where things go to wait for the end of a season.

Roxana came back on the ninth day.

I was in the kitchen at about two in the morning, because I could not sleep and I did not want to lie in our bed. I was standing at the counter with a glass of water, looking at nothing. And I heard the kiln door.

You need to know that sound. Her kiln was in a shed at the bottom of the garden. It had a heavy steel door with a latch, and when you opened it the hinges made a long dry squeal, two notes, high and then low, like a bird. I had heard that sound perhaps three thousand times in sixteen years. You do not mistake it.

I heard it. High and then low. Then the latch.

I went out into the garden in my bare feet. It was cold and the grass was wet. The shed was dark and the door was closed and padlocked, the way my mother had left it. The kiln was cold. I put my hand on it to be sure.

I stood there for a long time.

Then I went back to the house, and as I came in through the kitchen door I saw her. She was standing at the counter where I had been standing, with her back to me, in my old university sweatshirt, with her hair tied up with a pencil. She was looking down at something in her hands. A bowl, I think.

I said her name.

She was not there. There was the counter, and the glass of water I had left on it, and the light over the stove.

I want to tell you that I thought I was going mad. I did not. I did what I always do. I looked it up.

It is very common. That is the first thing I learned. Doctors call it a *grief hallucination*, or sometimes a *sense of presence*, and some studies say that half of all people who lose someone they love will see them, or hear them, or smell them, or feel them sit down on the edge of the bed, at least once in the months afterwards. For people who lose a husband or a wife, it may be more than half. It is not a sign that something is broken. It is the mind doing what it has always done. For years the mind has expected that person to be there, at that counter, at that hour. It has drawn them in so many times that it goes on drawing them, out of habit, after they are gone.

I read that sentence many times. *It goes on drawing them, out of habit.*

It made sense to me. It was the engine. My mind had studied Roxana for sixteen years the way it studied everything, and it had built a model of her so complete that the model went on running by itself.

She came back four more times that month. Twice I heard the kiln. Once I smelled the clay on her hands, wet and mineral, like a riverbank, as I was falling asleep. Once, the strangest, I was sitting in the dark living room in front of the shelf with the black box on it, and I felt her sit down on the arm of the sofa beside me, the way she always did, and I felt the sofa tilt under her weight.

I did not look. I knew if I looked she would be gone. So I sat still, and she sat still, and after a while the sofa came level again.

I did not tell anyone. Not my mother. Not Sahar.

I see now that I should have told Sahar. I think she was hearing the kiln too.

On the twenty-third night I found the thing that saved me. That is how I thought of it then. I want to keep the word, because it is what I believed, and this book is about what I believed.

I was at the kitchen table with my laptop at three in the morning, reading, as I did every night, about anything that would hold still long enough to be read. I had gone from grief to cremation, from cremation to the chemistry of bone, from bone to carbon. It was the operator's word, still sitting in my phone. *Carbon. Goes up the stack.*

And from carbon, in the way that one link leads to the next at three in the morning, I came to a page about diamonds.

I sat up.

There are companies, it said, that can make a diamond from a person.

I will tell you how it works, because I learned it that night and I have never stopped knowing it.

A diamond is carbon. Nothing else. The same element as the lead in a pencil and the soot in a chimney, only with the atoms packed into

a different shape, a tight three-dimensional lattice, each atom locked to four others, which is why a diamond is the hardest natural thing we know. In the earth, diamonds form about a hundred and fifty kilometres down, under heat and a pressure we can barely imagine, over hundreds of millions of years. Then a kind of volcanic eruption from very deep brings a few of them up to the surface, in pipes of rock.

But you do not need a hundred million years. Since the 1950s, people have been able to make diamonds in a machine. You take pure carbon, put it in a press with a tiny seed crystal of diamond, and squeeze it at the pressure of the deep earth and the heat of a furnace. The machine is called an HPHT press: high pressure, high temperature. The carbon crystallises onto the seed, atom by atom, and in a few weeks you have a stone. It is not an imitation. It is a real diamond, harder than anything, carbon in its tightest shape. It simply did not come out of the ground.

And the carbon can come from anywhere. From graphite. From sugar. From a lock of hair.

From what is left of a person.

The laboratory takes some of the remains, a pound or so, and draws out the carbon with acids and heat, and purifies it again and again until it is almost nothing but carbon. They turn it into graphite. They put the graphite in the press with a seed. A few weeks later, or a few months, they send you a diamond.

I read the pages of every laboratory I could find. There were not many. Two in Europe, one in America, a few others. I read the whole of every site. I read the reviews. I read the forums where people talked about the stones they had received, and showed photographs: small stones, most of them, on rings and pendants, and many of them blue.

*Blue*, the pages said, *because of boron*. A trace of the element boron stays with the carbon however clean you make it, and boron turns a diamond blue. The more boron, the deeper the blue. Every person's stone is a different shade. Some come out almost colourless. Some come out yellow, where the carbon picked up nitrogen in the press. No two are the same. *Like the person*, one page said, which made

me angry, because it was a sentence written to sell something, and it was also true.

I looked at the grey-blue bowl on the shelf beside the black box.

I thought of the white feather frozen inside her diamond, sixteen years ago, under the jeweller's loupe.

I felt it catch.

I want to describe the hook properly, because this is the one that took everything.

It was not a decision. It never is. It felt like warm water poured into a cold room. My back straightened. My breathing changed. The kitchen, which had been grey for twenty-three days, came into focus as if someone had wiped a window. The sound in my head, the engine running and running into the hole, changed its note. It had something in front of it.

It was three in the morning. I made coffee. I started a new spreadsheet.

I did not go to bed that night. In the morning my mother came downstairs in her dressing gown and found me at the table with four browser windows open and a page of notes in my handwriting, and she stopped in the doorway.

I looked up at her. I smiled. I had not smiled in twenty-three days.

I watched her face as she saw the smile. I will never forget it. It was not relief. It was the face of a woman in a basement in Tehran who hears the siren start.

## **The Spoon**

There was a choice to make, on the laboratory's form, and I made it without telling anyone.

You could have the diamond cut and polished by the laboratory and set in a ring or a pendant. Most people did. Or you could have it sent to you rough, the way it came out of the press, uncut, a small cloudy crystal like a piece of sea glass. Almost nobody chose that.

There was a note beside the box that said: *For customers who wish to use their own cutter.*

I ticked it.

I did not yet know why. I told myself I would find the best cutter in the world and pay him whatever he asked. I told myself that a stone this important should not be cut by a stranger in a factory in a hurry. All of that was true. But under it, at the bottom of my mind, the engine had already decided something, and it was waiting for me to catch up.

They needed a pound of her. The form said *a minimum of 500 grams*. They sent a small, heavy, padded box with a sealed jar inside it, and a printed sheet of instructions, and a pair of thin white gloves.

I did it on a Tuesday, in the middle of the day. My mother had taken Kaveh to the dentist. Sahar was at school.

I have thought about why I chose a day when the house was empty. I told myself it was because I did not want the children to see something upsetting. That was a lie, and I knew it was a lie even as I told it. I chose a day when the house was empty because I knew that if anyone saw me, they would stop me.

I took the black box down from the shelf and put it on the kitchen counter. I cut the metal tie on the bag with my mother's kitchen scissors. I looked for something to measure with. The measuring spoons were in the drawer, but there was something on the counter closer to my hand, and I picked it up without thinking.

It was my mother's gold tea spoon. She had polished it that morning and left it on a folded napkin by the kettle, the way she did every day in that house, because it was the one thing from her own mother she could hold.

I used it.

I put the jar on the kitchen scale, and I spooned Roxana into the jar, and I watched the numbers climb. A hundred grams. Two hundred. The small pale pieces of bone made a faint dry sound against the glass. I did not stop at five hundred. I thought: *more carbon, better*

*stone*. I stopped at a little over nine hundred, which was close to half of her. I sealed the jar. I put it in the padded box. I resealed the bag and put it back in the black box and put the black box back on the shelf beside the grey-blue bowl.

It looked exactly the same. That is what I told myself. It looked exactly the same.

I drove the padded box to the shipping office in the town at the bottom of the canyon and sent it by courier, insured, signature required. When I came back the house was still empty. The spoon was on the counter by the kettle, on its napkin, where I had put it down.

There was grey on it.

I saw that. I did not wash it. I do not know why I did not wash it. I think the engine had already moved on to the next thing, the tracking number, the delivery date, and the spoon was behind me, in the place where things go in and do not come out.

My mother found it that evening.

She picked it up from the napkin to stir her tea, and stopped, and turned it to the light over the stove. I was at the kitchen table with my laptop. I did not look up. I felt her looking at me across the kitchen for a long time.

"Kian," she said.

"Mm."

"Kian. What have you done?"

I told her. I told her about the laboratory and the press and the carbon. I told her it would be a diamond, a real one, and that Roxana would never be in a box on a shelf again, she would be something you could hold up to the light. I was excited. I could hear how excited I was. I talked for perhaps ten minutes and she did not interrupt me once.

When I stopped, she put the spoon down on the counter. She did not wash it either.

"Sahar wants to take her to the sea," she said. "At forty days. The *chehelom* [che-he-LOM]."

The *chehelom* is the fortieth day after a death. In Persian families there is a gathering then, food and prayers and a visit to the grave, and it is the end of the first and hardest part of mourning. Roxana had no grave. Sahar had decided, on her own, that the fortieth day would be the day they took her mother to Zuma.

"She has asked you three times," my mother said. "You said *later* every time."

I did not remember her asking. I believe that she did. I believe it now absolutely. But at the time I could not find it anywhere in my mind.

"There is plenty left for the sea," I said.

My mother looked at me. Then she said something I did not hear. I mean that exactly. Her lips moved, and she said a sentence, quietly, in Persian, and I was looking at the tracking page on the laptop to see whether the courier had collected the box, and the sentence went past me like a car on the road below the house.

I have tried for a long time to remember what she said. I cannot. I asked her, much later, and she would not tell me.

She went up to bed without her tea.

Sahar came home late that night. I heard her go into the living room. I heard her stop. Then I heard her go upstairs.

She did not come into the kitchen. She did not say anything. The next morning she came down for breakfast with her face washed and her hair tied back very tight, and she ate her cereal and talked to Kaveh about a film, and when I said good morning she said good morning.

I see now that she knew. I thought, at the time, that she had not noticed. A box on a shelf looks exactly the same.

But you cannot tell the weight of a thing by looking at it. You can only tell by holding it.

## **Bring Nothing**

The stone would take about six months to grow. The laboratory said so in the confirmation email: *Your diamond will be ready in approximately twenty-four to twenty-six weeks.*

Twenty-six weeks was a long time for the engine to have nothing in front of it. So it put something there.

I needed a cutter. That was the first question. The second came right behind it, the way the second move in chess is already inside the first: why did I need someone else?

I began, as I always begin, with reading. I read about cutting the way I had once read the dictionary: from the beginning, everything, without skipping. I learned that the cutting of diamonds has been centred for five hundred years on one small city in Belgium. Antwerp. That for most of the twentieth century the greater part of the world's rough diamonds passed through a few streets beside its railway station. That the families who cut there had passed the trade from father to son for generations, Jewish families first, then Armenian and Indian and Lebanese, and that the best of the old masters could look at a rough stone for a week before touching it.

I learned that most cutting today is done in India, in large factories, by young men working long shifts with machines that plan the cuts by laser and computer. That the old hand-cutting of Antwerp was dying. That there were perhaps a few dozen men left in the city who still cut by eye and hand the way it was done in 1919, and that most of them were old, and that almost none of them took apprentices.

I read for a week. Then I wrote to them.

I found the names of thirty-one hand-cutters in Antwerp, from trade lists and old newspaper articles and the websites of small workshops. I wrote to all of them. I wrote the same letter, honestly, in plain English. I said that my wife had died. I said that a diamond was being made from her. I said that I wanted to learn to cut it myself, with my own hands, and that I would pay anything and work any hours and was not afraid of how long it took.

Twenty-two of them did not answer. Seven answered politely, and said no. One of the seven said, quite kindly, that it took seven years

to make a cutter and that a man of forty-four with a broken wrist should find a good craftsman and spend the money on his children. Another of them wrote back a single line in Dutch, which I ran through a translator: *This is not a hobby.*

I read that line many times. It was the first thing anybody had said to me in a month that I completely agreed with.

The thirty-first letter was answered on the twenty-sixth day.

The email came from an address that was nothing but initials and numbers. There was no signature. There was no greeting. There was only an address in the diamond quarter, a floor number, and four words.

*Come. Bring nothing. E.*

I printed it. I do not know why. I printed it on the printer in my study and sat with the sheet of paper in my hands at the kitchen table, under the light over the stove, and read the four words perhaps a hundred times.

Then I searched for him. It was not hard. His name was Elias Karam [eh-LEE-as KA-ram]. He was about eighty. There was almost nothing about him online, which was its own kind of fact. An old trade directory listed him as a cutter and a dealer. An article from 1985 in a Belgian newspaper, about the last hand-cutters of Antwerp, had a photograph of a thin, dark man with a loupe on a cord around his neck, bent over a wheel, and one line under it: *Elias Karam, born in Sierra Leone to a Lebanese family, cutting a stone he has studied for eleven days.*

Eleven days. I looked at the photograph for a long time. It was the face. My father's face over a carpet. My face, I suppose, over anything.

I wrote back that night and asked when I should come.

He did not answer. I wrote again. He did not answer that either. I understood eventually that he had already answered. *Come* was not the first half of a conversation. It was the whole of it.

I left in the middle of winter, in the month the Persian calendar calls Dey [DAY], a little over four months after the accident.

I told my mother first. She was folding laundry in the spare room, and she went on folding it while I talked, sheet after sheet, the corners exactly matched. When I had finished she held one towel against her chest for a moment and did not fold it.

"How long?" she said.

"Until it's finished."

"That is not a length of time, Kian. That is a season."

I said nothing. She was right. She put the towel down on the pile, unfolded.

"I will stay with them," she said. "Of course I will stay. Where else would I be?" She looked at me. "But you should know what you are doing. You should say it out loud once. You are leaving your children four months after their mother died, to go and polish a stone."

"I'm going to make something out of her," I said. "So they will have her. So she doesn't just—" I didn't know how to finish. "Disappear."

My mother picked the towel back up and folded it, very carefully, into thirds.

"They have her," she said. "They are trying to give her back."

I told the children at dinner.

Kaveh asked how far Belgium was. I told him: nine thousand kilometres, a little more, eleven hours in a plane. He asked how many days I would be gone. I told him I didn't know. He thought about that very seriously, with his fork in the air, and then went on eating.

Sahar didn't ask anything. She listened, and she ate, and when I had finished she put her fork down on her plate, very precisely, at the angle that means *finished* in a restaurant, and she said, "May I be excused?" She had never asked to be excused from a table in her life. I said yes. She went upstairs.

I sat at the table. My mother cleared the plates. Kaveh stayed and watched me.

"Baba," he said. "Is it a season?"

I looked at him. Nine years old, with his hair sticking up at the back where he had slept on it, and his mother's eyes, and my engine.

"Yes," I said. "I think it is."

He nodded, as if that settled something. Then he got down from his chair and went to the fridge and looked at the calendar for a while. It was still on the month of the car. Nobody had turned it.

I left early in the morning, in the dark. My mother drove me to the airport. The children were asleep. Or Kaveh was. I went into his room and he was asleep on his back with his mouth open and a red Lego brick in his fist, and I stood over him for a minute and did not wake him.

Sahar's door was shut. There was light under it. I stood outside it with my hand raised to knock. I could hear nothing at all on the other side, not a phone, not music, nothing, which meant she was awake and listening to me stand there.

I did not knock. I told myself it would be kinder not to.

I had left my laptop open on the kitchen table, with the email on the screen. *Come. Bring nothing. E.* I did not notice until I was at the airport. I thought nothing of it. I thought, *my mother will close it.*

Three days later my mother sent me a photograph of the fridge. She did not write anything with it.

The car calendar was gone. In its place was a single sheet of paper from a school exercise book, taped up with too much tape, the way a nine-year-old tapes things. On it, in pencil, in Kaveh's careful handwriting that rubbed out every imperfect letter, he had drawn a grid of squares. Seven across. Many rows down. At the top it said, in capitals: BABA.

The first three squares had crosses in them.

There was no number at the bottom of the grid. He had not written an end date. He did not know one. He had simply drawn squares, and kept drawing them, all the way to the bottom edge of the paper.

### **The Diamond Quarter**

Antwerp in winter is grey in a way Los Angeles cannot imagine. Not the grey of fog, which moves. The grey of stone that has been wet for five hundred years.

I came out of the central station into a fine, steady rain that did not seem to fall so much as hang in the air. The station is enormous, a cathedral of iron and glass and marble built for a king, and I stood under its great dome for some minutes with my one bag, looking up. I had brought almost nothing. Two changes of clothes. A coat. My phone. My passport. The photograph of the old newspaper page, printed and folded in my wallet.

*Bring nothing.* I had taken him at his word.

The diamond quarter begins about a hundred metres from the station doors.

You would not know it was there. That is the first thing. It is three or four short streets of ordinary grey office buildings, six or seven storeys high, the kind you see in any European city. But the streets are closed to cars at both ends by steel posts that rise out of the road. There are cameras on every corner, on every lamppost, under the eaves of every building. There are police in a small booth at the corner with automatic weapons slung across their chests, and they watch everyone who walks in.

And the people. Men in long black coats and black hats, with beards and side curls, walking quickly with briefcases chained to their wrists. Indian men in quiet suits, speaking a language I later learned was Gujarati [goo-ja-RAA-tee], from the western coast of India, where much of the trade's next generation comes from. Older men, Armenian, Lebanese, Russian, Israeli. Almost no women. Almost no one who did not look as if they knew exactly where they were going and what was in their pocket.

It felt like walking into a church where everybody worshipped the same small thing and nobody spoke of it out loud.

The address was a narrow building at the end of the quietest of the streets. There was a steel door with no name on it and a row of buttons with numbers instead of names. I pressed the button for the fourth floor. Nothing happened for a long time. Then the door buzzed and clicked open, and I went in out of the rain.

There was a lift the size of a phone box, and a sign beside it in four languages that said it was out of order, and from the faded look of the sign it had been out of order for some years. I climbed four floors of narrow stairs. My wrist, newly out of its cast, ached in the cold. On the fourth floor there was a second steel door, and a camera above it, and a small grey button.

Before I could press it, the door opened.

He was smaller than I had imagined. That was the first thing. He was a thin, upright, dark-skinned old man, a little shorter than me, in a white shirt buttoned to the collar and grey trousers held up by braces. His hair was white and cut very short. His face was lined deeply, the way old wood is lined, but there was nothing soft in it. His eyes were very dark and very still.

Around his neck, on a black cord, was a loupe.

He looked at me for a long time without speaking. Not at my face. At me, the whole of me, from my wet shoes to my hair, the way I have seen a jeweller look at a stone through a window before he picks it up. His eyes stopped once on my left wrist, where the skin was still pale and thin from the cast.

"You held something very hard," he said.

I did not know what he meant. Then I did, and something cold went down the back of my neck. It was what the doctor in Pasadena had said, almost word for word.

"A door handle," I said.

He did not reply to that. He stepped back to let me in.

"Elias," he said.

"Kian."

"I know."

The workshop was one long room with a row of tall windows down one side, facing north. A cutter works by north light, I learned later. It is the only light that stays the same all day, with no sun coming into it, no warmth, no shadows that move. On a grey Antwerp morning it filled the room with an even, colourless brightness, like the inside of a cloud.

Under the windows stood three cutting wheels, each on its own heavy iron bench. They were flat iron discs about as wide as a dinner plate, mounted horizontally, like small record players made for a giant. Above each was a heavy arm with a clamp on the end. One wheel was turning, very fast and almost silent, with a sound like breath. The others were still, and covered with clean white cloths.

There was a long table down the middle of the room covered with tools I did not know the names of yet. There were jars of grey paste. There was a kettle and two glasses. There was a small electric heater that did very little. At the far end of the room, set into the wall, was a safe, an old one, painted green, as tall as a man.

And nothing else. No photographs. No certificates on the wall. No chair, except the one at the turning wheel and a single wooden stool beside the table.

He pointed at the stool. I sat. He sat at the wheel. He looked at me for a while longer.

"Thirty-one letters," he said. "I know. They telephoned each other about you. A man from Los Angeles whose wife is being made into a stone. The whole street laughed for a week."

"But you answered."

"I answered."

"Why?"

He took the loupe from his neck and turned it over in his fingers. It was very old. The brass was worn pale where his thumb had held it for, I suppose, sixty years.

"Because you said you were not afraid of how long it took," he said. "Every man who writes to me says that. You were the first one who was telling the truth." He put the loupe down on the bench. "I could see it in the letter. It was a very long letter, and every sentence was the same length."

I had not noticed that. I went back, later, and looked. He was right.

He did not teach me anything that day. He talked, a little. He made tea in the two glasses, very strong and very sweet, the way my mother makes it, and pushed one across the table.

"What did you bring?" he said.

"Nothing. Like you said."

"Good. Then you have room."

He drank his tea. Outside the north windows, the rain went on hanging in the air over the grey roofs.

"You will want to know the first rule," he said. "Everybody wants the first rule. Here it is. I will say it once, and I will say it again on the last day, and you will understand it on the last day and not before."

He put his glass down.

"Every stone carries one tension."

I waited. He let me wait.

"A diamond grows in the dark for a very long time," he said. "Under weight. And while it grows, the weight presses into it. Not everywhere the same. In one place more than the others. The stone remembers that place. It holds it, like a muscle holds a cramp. You cannot see it. Not with the eye, not with the loupe. But it is there, and it is waiting." He tapped the bench once, lightly, with one finger. "Find it before you cut. Or it finds you."

"What happens if it finds you?"

"The stone breaks," he said. "On the wheel. All at once. Into pieces. Sometimes into dust." He shrugged. "Then you have nothing, and it was your fault, because the tension was there from the beginning. It was always there. You only had to look."

I asked him about the safe. I could not help it. It was the only thing in the room that was closed.

He looked at me for a moment, the way my father had looked at me under the table in the bazaar. Then he got up, went to the far wall, and turned the dial on the old green safe, left and right and left, and pulled the heavy door open.

Inside were shelves. On most of them were small folded papers, white, each the size of a playing card, stacked in neat rows. Diamond papers, I learned later. Every stone in the trade travels folded inside one.

But on the top shelf, alone, was a small fold of grey cloth. It was soft and old, like a handkerchief that had been washed a thousand times. Something small was wrapped inside it. He did not touch it. He looked at it, and then at me.

"That is the Kono stone," he said. "A rough diamond I bought in Sierra Leone in 1999. I have never cut it."

Kono [KOH-noh] is a district in the far east of Sierra Leone, a small country on the Atlantic coast of West Africa. I knew a little of it from my reading. Its ground holds some of the richest diamond gravels in the world, and in the 1990s a long and terrible civil war was fought over them, and paid for with them.

"Twenty-seven years," I said. "Why haven't you cut it?"

He closed the safe. He spun the dial.

"Because I have not found the right hands," he said.

Then he sat back down at his wheel and did not say anything else for the rest of the day.

I found a room that night, through his directions, three streets from the workshop: a bed, a sink, a radiator that clanked, above a shop that sold kosher wine. From its window I could see the edge of the station roof and the steel posts at the end of the diamond quarter, shining wet under the streetlights.

I lay on the narrow bed and did not sleep. I was not unhappy. That is what I want to tell you, and it is the worst thing I have to tell you in this part of the book.

I lay in a cold room nine thousand kilometres from my children, with my wife's ashes on a shelf in a house in Topanga and half of her in a press in a laboratory somewhere, waiting to become a stone. And I was not unhappy. The engine was running. It had something in front of it, something enormous and difficult and very old, that would take everything I had. The world had gone quiet and narrow around one thing. Inside that quiet I was safe.

I thought of Kaveh's grid of squares on the fridge, with three crosses in it.

I thought: *I will make it up to them when the season ends.*

I put that thought in the place where things go in and do not come out. Then I turned on my side and watched the rain on the window until it got light.

## **The Mountain of Light**

*There is a diamond in the Tower of London, in a crown, behind thick glass, that has been fought over for seven hundred years. Its name is Persian: Koh-i-Noor [KOH-ee-NOOR], the Mountain of Light.*

*Nobody knows where it was found. The story says it came out of the riverbeds of southern India, long ago, when India was the only place on earth where diamonds were found at all. The story says it passed from king to king the way a fever passes from hand to hand.*

*In 1739 a Persian king named Nader Shah [naa-DER SHAAH] crossed the mountains with his army and took the city of Delhi from the Mughal emperor. He emptied the treasury. He took the Peacock Throne. He took everything. But the greatest diamond in the empire could not be found.*

*Then a woman of the emperor's household whispered to Nader Shah that the emperor kept it hidden in the folds of his turban.*

*So Nader Shah held a feast. And at the feast he proposed an old custom, an exchange of turbans between brothers, as a sign of friendship. The emperor could not refuse. They exchanged turbans. And that night, alone in his tent, Nader Shah unwound the cloth, and the stone fell out into his hand, and the story says he cried out, "Koh-i-Noor!" — "Mountain of light!" — and that is how it got its name.*

*He kept it eight years. Then his own officers murdered him in his tent. His grandson, who was blind, was tortured to tell where the family's jewels were hidden. The stone went to Afghanistan, to a king whose grandson wore it on his arm, and lost his throne, and fled, and lost the stone. It went to the Sikh ruler of the Punjab, who wore it on his arm, and died. His son was a boy of ten when the British took the Punjab, and they took the stone as part of the peace, and sent it across the sea to Queen Victoria.*

*There is a saying that travels with the stone. Nobody knows who first said it. "He who owns this diamond will own the world, but will also know all its misfortunes. Only God, or a woman, can wear it in safety."*

*In London it disappointed everyone. It had been cut in India long before, in the old way, to keep as much of the stone as possible, and it was large and grey and did not sparkle. So the Queen's husband brought a master cutter from Amsterdam, and a steam engine was set up to drive the wheel, and for thirty-eight days they ground away at the Mountain of Light to make it shine.*

*When they were done it weighed little more than half of what it had weighed before. More than eighty carats of it had gone into dust on the wheel.*

*Everyone agreed it shone better now.*

*Everyone agreed, too, though not out loud, that it was a little less itself.*

*The Queen wore it as a brooch. After her, it was only ever set in the crowns of queens, never kings, because of the saying.*

*It sits in its crown today, behind its glass, and every year millions of people walk slowly past it on a moving walkway that does not let them stop. They look at it for a few seconds each. Some of them want it so badly they can taste it. None of them can say why.*

### **III. SPLITTING**

## Worthless Stones

On the first morning he gave me a jam jar full of gravel.

That is what it looked like. Small, dull, greyish-brown pebbles, some no bigger than a grain of rice, some as big as a pea, with rough, frosted surfaces like old glass from a beach. There were perhaps two hundred of them. He put the jar down on the long table in front of my stool, unscrewed the lid, and tipped a few out onto a square of black felt.

"Diamonds," he said.

I picked one up. It was lighter than I expected, and colder. It did not shine. It did not do anything at all.

"Industrial," he said. "Bad colour, bad shape, full of cracks and dirt. In the trade they call them *boart* [BORT]. They are crushed into powder for saws and drills and for the paste on the wheel. This jar is worth about as much as a good dinner." He sat down at his wheel. "You will cut these. All of them. Badly. And when you have ruined every one, I will give you another jar."

"And her?"

He did not look up. "You will not cut her," he said. "You will cut a thousand stones that are nobody. Then, perhaps, her."

That was how the days began, and that was how they went on.

I arrived at eight. He was always there before me. I never once in two years saw him arrive or leave; he was simply there when I came and still there when I went. He made the tea in the two glasses. He handed me the jar. He went to his wheel. We did not speak, most days, until noon.

At noon he ate. Always the same: a piece of flat bread, some white cheese, a handful of olives, an apple cut into exact eighths with a small knife. He ate standing at the north window, looking down into the street. When he had finished he washed his hands at the little sink for a long time, and dried them on a clean towel, and then he would come over to the table and teach me one thing.

One thing a day. Never two.

On the second day he taught me where diamonds come from.

"You think the earth is solid," he said. "It is not. Under your feet, a long way down, the rock is hot and soft. Not liquid. Soft, like cold honey. It moves, very slowly, the way honey moves when you tip the jar."

A hundred and fifty kilometres down, he said, the heat is over a thousand degrees and the weight of the rock above presses down harder than anything on the surface could. In that place, if there is carbon, the carbon atoms are crushed together into the tightest shape they can make. That shape is a diamond. Most diamonds in the world grew there, he said, between one billion and three billion years ago. They are older than almost everything alive. Older than the first animals. Older than most of the rock you can see.

"Then they sit," he said. "For a billion years. In the dark. Under the weight."

"How do they come up?"

"Very fast." He almost smiled. "Every so often, deep down, the soft rock melts and boils up toward the surface. It comes up through a crack in the earth faster than a car on a motorway, and it carries everything it touches with it. Pieces of the deep. Diamonds. When it reaches the surface, it explodes. Then it cools and hardens in the shape of the pipe it came up through. A carrot, pointing down into the earth." He drew it in the air with one finger. "The rock is called *kimberlite* [KIM-ber-lite], after a town in South Africa where they first dug it out. The pipe can be a kilometre wide at the top. Inside it, scattered like raisins in a cake, are the diamonds."

"So every diamond came up in an explosion."

"Every natural diamond. Yes." He looked at the pebble in my fingers. "It grew for a billion years in silence, and then it came up in an afternoon, screaming. Remember that. It explains a great deal about them."

On the third day he taught me about weight.

A diamond is weighed in carats [KA-rats]. One carat is a fifth of a gram, he said, about the weight of a single dried seed. The word comes from the seeds of the carob tree, which merchants in the old markets of the Middle East and the Mediterranean once used as weights, because people believed every carob seed weighed exactly the same.

"They do not," he said. "But people wanted them to. That is the beginning of the diamond trade. A small thing that people agreed to believe."

On the fourth day he taught me the four Cs, the four qualities a stone is judged by. I knew them already from my diamond season, and I said so. He waited until I had finished, then told me again, as if I had not spoken.

*Carat*: the weight. *Colour*: how close the stone is to having none at all, because the best white diamonds are the ones you can see straight through, like water. *Clarity*: how few flaws are trapped inside it. *Cut*: the shape, the angles, the finish.

"Three of these the earth gives you," he said. "You cannot change them. The weight is what the earth gave you. You can only lose it. The colour is the colour. The flaws are inside, and they were put there a billion years ago." He held up one finger. "Only the cut is yours. Only the cut is a man's work. A great stone badly cut is a pebble. A modest stone cut well can stop a room."

"So everything depends on the cutter."

"No," he said. "Everything depends on the stone. The cutter only decides whether to listen to it."

I want to tell you about my hands in those weeks, because they are the first part of me that understood what I had done.

They were useless. That was the first thing I learned. I had always thought of myself as a man with good hands. I had rebuilt an engine. I had ground a telescope mirror to a millionth of an inch. I had tied flies for trout and soldered circuit boards and once, during the bread season, made a loaf that my mother said tasted like Tehran.

None of that meant anything here. The stones were too small, too hard, too slippery. They jumped out of the tweezers. They rolled off the felt and vanished into the cracks of the old floorboards, and I had to get down on my knees with a torch and search. By the end of the first week my fingertips were cut in a dozen places from the sharp edges of broken board. My left wrist ached from morning to night. I could not hold a loupe steady for more than a minute without my eye watering.

Elias watched all this without comment. Once, when I dropped a stone for the fourth time in an hour and swore, he said, without looking round from his wheel, "Your hands are not slow. Your mind is fast. Wait for your hands."

I did not understand that for a long time.

What I understood at once was the quiet.

I had expected to miss the noise of my life. The phone, the emails, the arguments, the thousand small demands of being a father, a son, a widower, a man with a house and a bank account and a broken car on the back of a truck somewhere in the Valley. I did not miss any of it. Within a week it was gone. The north light filled the room. The wheel turned with its sound like breathing. The rain hung over the grey roofs. My whole life narrowed down to a square of black felt, a pair of tweezers, and a small dull stone that would not do what I wanted.

I want to describe this narrowing honestly, from the inside, because people who do not have the engine think it must feel like suffering.

It does not. It feels like relief.

It is the relief of a man who has been carrying a heavy bag a long way and is allowed, at last, to put it down. The bag is everything else. Your children. Your mother. Your grief. Your shame. The narrowing does not make those things go away. It puts them in a room, and closes the door, and you can no longer hear them. And in the quiet that is left, there is only the problem in front of you, and the problem is simple, and the problem is hard, and nothing that is simple and hard has ever hurt you.

It is the basement in Tehran. It is the tiles on the floor and the exercise book under the pillow. It is the safest place in the world.

I knew, even then, that it was not a good thing that I felt this way, four months after my wife died, nine thousand kilometres from my children. I knew it the way you know, in a dream, that you are dreaming. It made no difference at all.

## **The Grain**

A diamond has a grain, like wood.

That was the lesson of the sixth week, and it took him a whole afternoon, the only time he ever broke his rule of one thing a day.

"Look," he said, and he put a stone under the big magnifier on the table and turned on the lamp.

It was a better stone than my boart, a clean pale rough about the size of a chickpea, shaped like two small pyramids stuck together at their bases. He said this was the shape a diamond most wants to grow in. The word for it is *octahedron* [ok-ta-HEE-dron], which means *eight faces*. Four sides on the top pyramid, four on the bottom.

"Inside," he said, "the atoms are stacked in layers. Flat layers, like the pages of a book. The layers run in the same direction as those eight faces. Between the pages, the hold is weaker. Not weak. Nothing about a diamond is weak. But weaker." He touched one face of the stone with the tip of a fine steel pin, very lightly. "If you strike a diamond along the page, it opens like a book. One blow. Clean. Flat. A mirror on both sides."

"And if you strike it against the page?"

"Then you have struck the hardest natural thing in the world as hard as you can, with a piece of steel, in the wrong place." He put the pin down. "You will hurt your hand. You will hurt the stone. Or the stone will break the way it wants to break, and not the way you want, and then it is a different stone."

The old word in the trade for this is *cleaving* [KLEE-ving]. It is a strange word. It means to split something apart, and it also means to hold on to something tightly, the way a man cleaves to his wife in

the old marriage vows. Elias told me that, almost in passing, and I wrote it down. I did not see then why it would matter.

Splitting a stone, he said, takes a minute. Planning the split takes as long as it takes.

He gave me a stone and a loupe and a notebook and told me to find the grain.

I looked for three days. I turned the stone under the lamp a thousand times. I learned to see the faint lines on its surface, very fine, like the growth rings of a tree, that show which way the layers run. I drew them in the notebook. I drew the stone from six sides. I measured it with a small brass gauge that read to a hundredth of a millimetre. I made a page of calculations. On the fourth morning I showed him where I would split it.

He looked at my drawings for a long time, without speaking, turning the pages. He looked at the stone. Then he closed the notebook and gave it back to me.

"Again," he said.

"What's wrong with it?"

"Nothing is wrong with it. You looked at the stone for three days. You looked at your drawings for one." He pushed the stone back across the felt. "Look at the stone."

On the ninth day of that stone I found it.

I cannot tell you how. I can tell you only what it was like. I was looking through the loupe, the way I had looked a hundred times, and I was not thinking. For the first time in my life, perhaps, I was not thinking at all. I was simply looking. And the stone turned, very slightly, in the light, and I saw the grain the way you see a face in a crowd. All at once, without searching. It was simply there, running through the stone like the lines in my father's palm.

I put the loupe down. My hands were shaking.

Elias was at his wheel, with his back to me. He did not turn around.

"Now," he said.

To split a diamond, you first cut a small groove in its surface, exactly along the grain, using the sharp edge of another diamond, because only a diamond is hard enough to scratch a diamond. This takes an hour. Then you set the stone in a holder of hard wax and lock the holder upright in a small iron cup. You set a thin steel blade into the groove. You hold the blade with your left hand, very lightly. You take a small iron rod in your right hand.

And you strike, once.

There is no second blow. If the first is wrong, the second only finishes what the first broke.

I sat with the blade in the groove and the rod in my hand for, I think, ten minutes. I could feel the stone's grain through the steel. I could feel my own pulse in my fingertips. I could hear the wheel turning behind me and the rain on the window and, far away, the bell of a tram going round the station square.

Elias did not speak.

I struck.

There was a small, flat sound, like a pebble dropped onto a tile floor. And the stone fell open in the holder, in two pieces, and each piece had a face as flat and bright as a mirror. I picked one up with the tweezers and turned it to the north light, and the light went into it and came back out at me, clean, like water.

I want to tell you what that felt like, because it was the best moment I had had since a night in a garage in Topanga with an engine singing. And because it frightens me now, how good it was.

It was warm water through the whole of my body. It was the twenty-ninth night of the Rubik's cube, and the last move of the San Diego final, and the first time the trading model made money on its own. It was every summit I had ever reached, folded into one small flat sound. For about a minute I was not a widower. I was not a father who had left his children. I was not a son, or a man who had once had a bruise across his chest the shape of a seat belt. I was a man who had opened a stone along its grain, with one blow, the way it wanted to be opened.

Behind me, Elias turned off his wheel. It was the first time I had ever heard the room without it. The silence was enormous.

He came and stood beside me and looked at the two halves on the felt. He picked one up and looked at it through his loupe. He put it down.

"Good," he said.

That was all. It was the only time he used that word in my first year.

I went back to my room that night and lay on the narrow bed above the wine shop, and I could not sleep, I was so happy. Then I remembered that I had not called home in four days.

I lay there for a while, deciding whether to call. It was the middle of the afternoon in Los Angeles. Kaveh would be at school. My mother would be at the market, or resting. Sahar would be at school, or would say she was.

I decided I would call in the morning. In the morning, I went to the workshop.

## **Her**

The stone came in the spring.

The laboratory had said twenty-four to twenty-six weeks. It was twenty-five. I knew the date it was due, of course. I had known it since the day I posted the jar. I had a countdown on my phone. I had checked the tracking page every morning before I left my room and every night when I got back to it. On the last week I checked it at the noon break too, standing in the corridor outside the workshop with my phone in my hand while Elias ate his apple at the window.

I had given the laboratory the workshop's address. Elias had told me to. "Nobody signs for anything at that wine shop," he said. "Things go missing. Here, there is a camera, a door and me."

On the morning it was due, he sent me out.

He did it so naturally that I thought nothing of it. He had run out of the olive oil he used to clean the wheel; it had to be a particular kind, from a particular shop on the other side of the river, a

forty-minute walk each way. And while I was there, he said, I should stop at the bank on the corner of the main street and change some money for him. He gave me an envelope of notes and a list in his tiny, upright handwriting.

I said that the stone was coming today.

"Then it will be here when you get back," he said. "Unless you would like to stand in the door all morning like a dog waiting for its master."

I went. I was gone for nearly three hours. The bank had a queue, and the oil shop was closed until eleven, and I walked along the river in the rain, checking my phone every few minutes. At ten past ten the tracking page changed. *Delivered. Signed for: E. KARAM.*

I ran the last part of the way back. I am a man of forty-five and I had not run anywhere in years. I ran across the station square with a litre of oil in a paper bag and my heart going like my mother's against my back in the basement in Tehran.

He was sitting at the long table when I came in. There was no box anywhere. No packaging, no paper, no courier envelope. The table was clean. In the middle of it lay a square of black felt, and in the middle of the felt was a stone.

He did not stand up. He did not say anything as I came in. He looked at me, and then at the stone, and then back at me.

"This is your wife," he said.

I sat down on the stool. My legs did it without me.

The stone was rough, uncut, the size of a small fingernail, and shaped like a rounded box, its corners worn soft. It was not blue. That was the first thing I noticed, and it went through me like a cold draught. I had expected blue. I had read about blue for six months, the boron, *the more boron the deeper the blue*. I had imagined the grey-blue of the bowl on the shelf at home, the colour of the sea at Zuma just after sunset.

This stone was yellow. A soft, deep, warm yellow, like honey held up to a window, or the last light on a wall at the end of a summer day.

"It isn't blue," I said. My voice sounded strange.

"No," said Elias.

"The pages said they're usually blue. From the boron."

"Usually." He folded his hands on the table. "Sometimes the carbon takes up nitrogen in the press, from the air, from the metal. Nitrogen makes them yellow. Sometimes a little. Sometimes like this." He tilted his head at the stone. "Your laboratory will have told you. Somewhere in the small print."

They had. I remembered it. *Some come out yellow, where the carbon picked up nitrogen in the press.* I had read it a dozen times and forgotten it, because I had wanted blue.

"It's warmer," I said. "Than I thought. She was warm."

He said nothing.

I picked it up.

I want to tell you about this moment exactly, because later, it was the moment I could not stop going back to.

I did not weigh it. I did not measure it. I did not put it under the magnifier or look at it through the loupe or check it against the laboratory's certificate or write down anything at all. For the first time in my life, I held something important in my hand and did not measure it.

I just held it. It was cold at first and then, slowly, it was the temperature of my hand. It sat in my palm, very small, very heavy for its size, with the north light coming through it and laying a small soft patch of gold on the lines of my skin.

I closed my hand around it. I bent over the table with my closed hand against my forehead and I wept, for the first time since the hospital in Pasadena. I wept for a long time. I wept the way Kaveh cried when Sahar put the red brick in the wrong tray. It came from somewhere below thinking.

Elias did not touch me. He did not leave. He sat across the table with his hands folded and waited, the way you wait for weather to pass.

When I had finished, he got up and made tea in the two glasses and put one in front of me.

"Put her in the safe," he said. "You are not ready to look at her. You will not be ready for a long time."

He opened the old green safe and I put the stone in, in a fresh white paper, on the second shelf.

As I did it, I noticed something. I want to record it here only because I noticed it, and I am trying to put down everything I noticed. On the top shelf the small grey fold of cloth that held the Kono stone was lying a little to the left of where it had been. Perhaps a finger's width. The cloth was folded the same way, the same soft grey, tucked in at the same corner.

I noticed it, and I put it in the part of my mind where things wait. A man as careful as Elias, I thought, must take it out sometimes. He must look at it at night when I am not there. After twenty-seven years.

He closed the safe and spun the dial.

"Tomorrow," he said, "you will go back to the jar."

### **Breath on a Window**

It was perhaps three weeks later that he taught me the lesson about fire.

It was a Thursday. The rain had stopped for the first time in a month, and the north light was clean and cold. I was at the table with my jar of boart. I had cut maybe forty of them by then, badly, and split maybe twenty, and broken ten, and the floor around my stool was a small field of ruined stone.

At noon he ate his apple at the window, and washed his hands for a long time at the sink, and came over to the table.

"Today," he said, "you will learn what a diamond is."

He set a small block of white firebrick on the table, the kind used to line kilns. On the brick he put a pair of long steel tongs. Beside

them he put a torch, a small one, of the kind jewellers use for soldering, connected by two thin hoses to two steel bottles under the table. One bottle was oxygen. I knew that from the label. The other I did not know.

Then he took a small white paper from his shirt pocket and unfolded it on the felt.

Inside was a stone. A small, rough, pale stone, a little smaller than a pea, almost colourless. It had a faint grey cast in the north light, a little cloudy, like the sea on a dull day. Like the colour, I thought, and the thought came and went in less than a second, of a grey-blue bowl on a shelf, nine thousand kilometres away.

"A lab stone," he said. "Made in a press, not in the earth. Cheap. Worth nothing. The factories in India make them by the bucket now." He picked it up with the tongs and held it out to me. "Hold it."

I took the tongs. The stone sat between their tips.

"What do you know about diamonds?" he said.

"They're carbon."

"Yes. What else?"

"They're the hardest natural thing there is. Only a diamond can cut a diamond. They last forever."

"Two of those are true," he said. He lit the torch. It came alive with a soft roar and a cone of flame, blue at the heart, almost invisible at the edges. "Hold the stone in the flame. Not at the tip. Here, where the blue is."

I held it there.

For a while, nothing happened.

The tongs grew hot in my hand. The stone sat in the blue heart of the flame, and it did not change. I thought perhaps nothing would. A diamond is forever. Everyone knows that.

Then it began to glow.

A dull red first, deep, like the coals of a fire in the last hour of the night. Then orange. It was the colour of the inside of the retort in

the Valley, the colour of the firebrick behind the glass. I remember that I thought of the retort, and that I made myself stop thinking of it, because I did not want that colour on this.

Then it turned yellow. Then white. Not the white of a stone. The white of a star. It was so bright I could not look straight at it, and I looked at it anyway, with my eyes watering, holding the tongs as still as I have ever held anything.

And as I watched, it got smaller.

Not cracking. Not breaking. Shrinking. Its edges drew in very slowly, the way the edge of a drop of water draws in on a hot stove. It grew round. It grew smaller. It went on burning, in perfect silence, a tiny white sun in the jaws of the tongs, getting smaller and smaller and smaller.

And then it was gone.

There was nothing between the tips of the tongs. No ash. No smoke that I could see. No black mark on the steel. The flame roared on, blue and empty, where the stone had been.

Elias reached over and turned off the torch.

I sat holding the tongs. Neither of us spoke for a long time.

"Where did it go?" I said at last.

"Into the air," said Elias. "Into this room. A diamond is carbon. In fire, with enough air, carbon joins the oxygen and becomes a gas, the same gas you breathe out. It does not leave anything behind, because there is nothing in it but carbon. Nothing to leave." He took the tongs gently out of my hand and laid them on the firebrick. "A Frenchman named Lavoisier [la-VWAH-zee-ay] did this in Paris, two hundred and fifty years ago, with a great glass lens and the sun. He burned a diamond under a glass jar, and tested the air it turned into, and proved what it was made of. Kings had killed for diamonds for a thousand years. He showed them what they had been killing for. Breath." He paused. "You are breathing some of it now."

I breathed in. I could not help it.

"So it isn't forever," I said.

"Nothing is forever. A diamond only lasts a long time because nobody burns it." He folded up the white paper it had come in, very small, and put it in his shirt pocket. "You see how simple it is? It does not resist. It does not crack. It does not leave a mark. It goes back to what it was before anybody wanted it."

He looked at the empty tips of the tongs.

"Like breath on a cold window," he said.

I said it was beautiful.

I want to put that down plainly, because it was the truth, and because I would give anything now not to have said it. I said: "That was the most beautiful thing I have ever seen."

Elias did not answer at once. He was not looking at the tongs any more. He was looking at me. He was looking at my face very closely, the way he looked at a stone under the lamp, the way he had looked at me on the first morning in his doorway, from my wet shoes to my hair. He watched my face for a long time.

"Yes," he said. "It was."

Then he got up and went back to his wheel, and turned it on, and the room filled again with its sound like breathing, and he did not say anything else that day.

That night in my room above the wine shop I could not stop seeing it. The red, the orange, the white. The tiny sun getting smaller. The empty steel. I lay with my eyes closed and watched it again and again, and every time it was beautiful, and every time, at the very end, at the moment of vanishing, something in my chest closed up like a fist, and I did not know why.

I put it down, I suppose, to the retort. To the colour of the fire. To grief.

I did not put it down to anything else. There was nothing else to put it down to.

## Carbon

In the second week of summer I wrote to the laboratory.

I did not have a reason. That is what I told myself. The stone was in the safe, on the second shelf, in its white paper, and I had not looked at it since the day it came. I was still on the jar. I was getting better. I was splitting four stones out of five clean now, and Elias had started me on the wheel, polishing small flat faces onto boart that would never be worth anything. Every day the world was the felt and the stone and the north light, and every day it was enough.

But at night, in my room, the engine wanted something. It always does, at night. It does not want rest. It wants a problem.

So I wrote the laboratory a letter with fourteen questions in it.

I asked how much carbon they had drawn from the remains I had sent. I asked about the purity, the stages of cleaning, the temperature and pressure in the press, the type of seed crystal, the growth time. I asked for the paperwork, the logs of the whole process, everything they had. I numbered the questions. I am not proud of the letter. It is the kind of letter that a man writes to a garage about his car.

They answered in eight days. It was a long, polite, careful email from someone who signed herself as a member of the *client care team*, and it was the kindest letter I have ever received from a company, and it was, I think, the worst news of my life.

I will put it down plainly, the way she did.

When a body is cremated, she wrote, almost everything that is made of carbon burns away and goes up into the air. What comes back to the family is mostly bone. And bone is mostly not carbon. It is mostly a mineral, calcium and phosphate, the same hard white stuff as teeth. Only a small amount of carbon survives the fire, a few grams in all the remains of a grown person, sometimes less.

From the nine hundred grams I had sent them, she wrote, they had drawn out and purified all the carbon they could. It was a good sample. They were pleased with it. But the amount of carbon in it was small, as it always is. To grow a stone of the size I had ordered,

they had done what they do in every case, and what was set out on page four of the agreement I had signed: they had added carbon to it. Pure carbon, graphite, from their own stores, mixed in with hers before it went into the press.

She did not say how much. I asked, in a second email, at three in the morning. She answered the next day. She said that it varied from case to case, but that in a stone of my size, the carbon from the person was usually *a meaningful part of the whole*, and that many families found comfort in thinking of their stone as made *with* their loved one, rather than entirely *from* them.

A meaningful part. I worked it out. Of course I worked it out. I took the figures she had given me and the figures in the research and I made a spreadsheet in my room above the wine shop, at four in the morning, by the light of the laptop. At best, the stone in the safe was perhaps a fifth Roxana. At worst, much less. The rest of it was graphite from a jar on a shelf in a laboratory in a country she had never been to.

I sat on the edge of the bed with the laptop on my knees and the numbers on the screen. Outside the window, the sky over the station roof was beginning to go grey.

I want to tell you what I felt, and I want to be honest, because this is the part of the book where you will begin to be afraid of me.

I did not feel that I had been tricked. I had signed the agreement. It was on page four. I had read page four. I read everything. I had simply not let it in.

What I felt was this. For about a minute, a door opened. I saw, through the door, that I had taken half of my wife out of a box with my mother's spoon and sent her away, and left my children, and crossed the world, for a stone that was mostly something else. I saw Sahar's face at breakfast, and her hair tied back too tight. I saw Kaveh's grid on the fridge. I saw that the stone could not be what I needed it to be. Nothing could.

I saw all of that, clearly, for about a minute.

And then the engine said: *a fifth is still her*.

It said: *a fifth is more than anyone else has.*

It said: *you have already learned to split the grain. You cannot stop now. You do not know how to polish yet.*

And the door closed.

I closed the laptop. I washed my face in the little sink. I put on my coat and went out into the grey street, and walked the three streets to the workshop, and climbed the four floors, and Elias was there, as he was always there, and he made the tea, and he handed me the jar, and I went back to work.

He looked at me once that morning, over his wheel, for a long time. He did not ask me anything. I think he knew what had been in the email. I think he had known, the day the stone came, that sooner or later I would ask the question, and get the answer, and keep going anyway.

I think that was the day he was sure of me.

## **Calls Home**

Los Angeles is nine hours behind Antwerp. When I finished at the workshop at seven in the evening, it was ten in the morning in Topanga. When I woke in my room at six, it was nine at night there, and Kaveh was going to bed.

So the calls were short. They had to be. That is what I told myself.

We did them by video, on my mother's tablet, propped on the kitchen counter in Topanga against the fruit bowl. Most of the time what I saw was my mother's face too close to the camera, and behind her the kitchen I had left, the light over the stove, the corner of the fridge.

Kaveh was always there. He would climb up onto the stool by the counter and put his face very close to the screen, so close that I could see only one of his eyes, and tell me things. He told me about school, in great detail, in order, starting from when the bus came. He told me that he had started a collection of bottle tops and had a hundred and nine. He told me about a boy in his class who said that his father was dead, and that Kaveh had said no, he's in Belgium,

and the boy had said that was the same thing, and Kaveh had hit him.

He told me that in a flat voice, as if he were reading it out of a book. He showed me the grid on the fridge. My mother took the tablet over and held it up so I could see. The single sheet of exercise paper had become two sheets, then three, taped together end to end, running down the side of the fridge toward the floor. Every square had a neat cross in it. There was no number at the bottom. Just squares, and more squares.

"How many is it now?" I asked him.

"A hundred and four," he said at once. He did not have to look.

Sahar was never there.

She was at school. She was at a friend's. She was asleep. She was in the shower. She had a headache. Once, my mother turned the tablet toward the stairs and I saw her, for half a second, on her way up, in a sweatshirt that was mine and then had been her mother's, and I said her name, and she kept walking, and I heard her door close in the quiet way, the way that was louder than a slam.

"Give her time," my mother said.

I said I would. I said it as if time were something I had a great deal of and was generous with.

I am going to tell you something about those calls that I have never told anyone.

I watched the clock.

Not all the time. Not on purpose. But in every call there was a moment, usually about four or five minutes in, when I would notice that my eyes had gone to the small numbers in the corner of the screen. And with the numbers came a thought, not even in words. It was the feeling you get when someone talks to you during the best part of a film. There was a stone on the felt in the workshop, three streets away, half planned. There was a face I had not finished polishing. There was the north light, which would be gone soon.

My son would be telling me about the bus, in order, from the beginning. And part of me would be at the wheel.

I noticed this. I want to be clear that I noticed it. Every time, I noticed it, and I was ashamed, and I made myself look away from the clock and back at Kaveh's one enormous eye in the screen.

And every time, a minute later, I looked at the clock again.

Sahar turned sixteen in the spring, in the month the Persian calendar calls Ordibehesht [or-dee-be-HESHT], the second month of spring.

I knew the date. Of course I knew the date. I had it in my phone with three reminders. I sent money. I sent a long message, carefully written, about the day she was born and the window going grey and pink and her fist closed on my collar in the dark kitchen. I asked my mother to make the cake from the recipe Roxana always used, the one with cardamom and rosewater.

I did not call. The day fell on a Tuesday. On that Tuesday I was splitting a stone, a real one, the first clean rough Elias had trusted me with, and the split had to be done in the morning light, and I had been planning it for eleven days.

I told myself I would call that evening. In the evening it was morning in Los Angeles and she was at school. I told myself I would call that night. That night I fell asleep in my clothes on the narrow bed.

She sent me one line, the next day. It was the first message she had sent me since I left.

*thanks for the money.*

No capital letter. A full stop at the end.

I read it perhaps two hundred times. I wrote a dozen replies and deleted them. In the end I wrote: *Happy birthday, sweetheart. I'm sorry I didn't call. I love you.*

She did not answer.

I put the phone face down on the bed, the way I had once put it face down on the workbench in the garage, so that its buzzing would not

shake the mirror. And in the morning I went back to the workshop, and Elias made the tea, and handed me the jar.

Here is the worst of it, and then I will stop.

That night, lying awake, I understood perfectly well what I was doing. I could have written it down as clearly as Roxana wrote the seasons on the fridge. *THE STONE SEASON. Expected end: unknown.* I knew my children were on the other side of a door I had closed. I knew the door was in my own mind and that I was the one holding it shut.

And I thought, quite calmly: *I will make it up to them when the season ends.*

I had thought it before. In the basement. At sixteen, in the doorway with the trophy. In the garage, every night of the car. I had thought it so many times in my life that it no longer felt like a thought. It felt like a fact.

I did not ask myself what would happen if the season did not end.

I did not ask myself what I would do if, when it ended, there was nobody left on the other side of the door to make it up to.

I turned over on the narrow bed above the wine shop, and listened to the trams going round the station square, and planned tomorrow's stone.

**The Cutter Who Waited**

*They tell this one in the cafés behind the station in Antwerp, late, when the trade is finished for the day and the old men have had their second glass. Nobody knows if it is true. Nobody minds.*

*There was once a cutter in this city, they say, who was the best of his generation. Kings sent him their stones. When he was young he could look at a rough for a week and see inside it the way a midwife sees a child. When he was old he could do it in a day.*

*And in his safe he kept one stone that he never cut.*

*It was the finest rough he had ever held. It had come to him in his middle years, from far away, from a place he never named, and he paid for it a price he never named either. The other cutters knew it was there. Sometimes, late at night, when they passed his window, they saw his lamp lit and his shape at the table, and they knew he had it out, under the glass, and was looking at it.*

*Year after year, they asked him why he did not cut it.*

*"Not with these hands," he said.*

*They thought he meant his hands were not good enough. They laughed. His hands were the best in the city.*

*"Then whose?" they said.*

*"Clean ones," he said.*

*Forty years he waited. Apprentices came and went. Some were brilliant. Some were faithful. Some were both. He watched each of them for a year, two years, and then he sent them away, or let them stay and never showed them the stone. The street said he would die with it in his safe, uncut, and be buried with it in his pocket, and good luck to the gravediggers.*

*Then one winter a young man came to his door, from very far away, who knew nothing. Who had never held a diamond in his life. Who had come for a reason of his own, which had nothing to do with the old man, and which filled him so completely that he hardly saw anything else.*

*The old man took him on. The street was astonished.*

*And in the end, they say, it was this boy who cut the stone. Not knowing what it was. The old man simply put it in front of him one morning, among the others, and said, "This one next." And the boy cut it the way he cut everything that year, as if his life depended on it, because to him, it did. And it came out of his hands more beautiful than anything the city had seen in a generation.*

*The old men in the cafés always stop here, and drink, and look at each other.*

*Then somebody always asks the question. Was that fair? To the boy?*

*And somebody always answers, the same way, in the same words, as if it were the end of a prayer.*

*"Clean hands are only hands that do not know what they are holding."*

## **IV. GRINDING**

## **Four in the Morning**

He brought her out of the safe at the end of summer.

He did not say anything. He simply came to the table one morning, after the tea, and instead of the jar he put down a white paper, and unfolded it, and there she was on the felt. The soft yellow. The rounded corners. The north light going into her and coming back the colour of honey.

"Plan," he said. "Only plan. Do not touch her with anything but your eyes."

I planned her for four months.

Planning, he had taught me, is most of cutting. You look at a rough stone and you decide what is inside it. Not what it is, but what it could become. Every rough holds many possible stones, the way a block of marble holds many possible statues, and only one of them can be cut. To make one, you must grind away all the others. Whatever you take off is gone forever, as dust on the wheel.

"Most of the stone you will throw away," he said. "Half. Sometimes more. The art is in knowing which half."

So I looked. I looked at her under the lamp, under the loupe, under the big magnifier, in the north light of morning and the flat grey light of afternoon. I drew her from every side, as I had drawn the board, but a hundred times more carefully. I found her grain. I found her flaws, small ones, and I gave each of them a name in my notebook, the way an astronomer names stars. I measured her to a hundredth of a millimetre, again and again, until I knew her shape the way I had known the Rubik's cube: with my eyes closed, all six faces at once.

And as I planned, the hours went.

I began to arrive earlier.

Seven. Then six. Then, by the autumn, four in the morning, walking the three empty streets in the dark under the cameras, past the police booth where a bored young officer would lift two fingers to

me from inside the glass. I climbed the four floors in the dark, and pressed the grey button, and the door opened.

He was always there.

I want to put that down plainly, because it began to frighten me a little, and because I never found out how. At four in the morning, at midnight, on a Sunday, on Christmas Day, when the whole city was shut and silent and the steel posts were up at both ends of the street, I pressed the button and the door opened and he was at his wheel in the north window, in his white shirt buttoned to the collar, as if he had been sitting there since the day he was born.

He never asked why I had come so early. He made the tea. He went back to his wheel.

I stopped eating breakfast. Then I stopped eating lunch. I would eat something at night, standing at the sink in my room, bread, cheese, whatever was there, the way Elias ate his apple at the window, as fuel. I lost weight. My trousers slipped. I tightened my belt to the last hole, and then made a new hole with the point of a pair of scissors, and then another.

I slept three hours a night, then two. Sometimes I did not sleep. I would lie on the narrow bed with my eyes closed and see her on the felt, turning slowly under the lamp, and at three I would give up and get dressed and walk to the workshop.

And I was happy.

That is the thing I have to keep saying, because it is the thing no one believes. I was happier than I had been since the night in the garage with the engine singing. My body was falling apart and my children were nine thousand kilometres away and my wife was in a box on a shelf and in a stone on a felt and in neither, and I was happy. The burn does that. It burns away everything that hurts. It burns away everything else, too, and you do not notice, because you are warm.

In the autumn he taught me grinding.

The trade's word is *bruting* [BROO-ting], and it is the oldest part of the craft, older than the wheel. It is how a cutter gives a stone its outline, the round shape you see when you look down on a diamond ring from above. You do it by rubbing one diamond against another.

Nothing softer will touch it. Today the big factories in India cut and shape most diamonds with lasers, which burn a line through the stone with heat instead of grinding it. But the old hand-cutters of Antwerp still do it the way it was done for five hundred years, stone against stone. So you set the stone you are shaping in a small spinning holder on a lathe, and you take a second diamond, a rough ugly worthless one, fixed to the end of a long handle, and you press it against the spinning stone. And the two diamonds grind each other. Slowly, with a high thin whine, like a mosquito in your ear, they wear each other down, and a fine grey dust falls from them like ash.

"Only diamond cuts diamond," Elias said, the first time he showed me. He said it the way you say something everybody knows, like *water is wet*. It is a saying in the trade, very old, and in Dutch and in Yiddish and in Gujarati they say it the same way.

I wrote it in my notebook. Then I sat with it for a long time.

It is true of grief, I thought. It is true of obsession. Nothing outside it can touch it. Only another one like it can wear it down.

I did not then think about what that meant for the two of us, in that room, at four in the morning, grinding.

## **Short Sleeves**

He told me about Sierra Leone in the winter, a year after I came. It was the only lesson I ever asked for.

It began because I asked. I was at the lathe, and I had stopped for tea, and I asked him where he was born. It was the first personal question I had asked him in a year. He looked at me over his glass for a while.

"Kono," he said. "You know this."

"I know the word. I don't know the place."

He was silent for so long I thought he would not answer. Then he put his glass down and began to talk, in his flat, even, unhurried voice, the voice he used for the grain and the carats and the four Cs, as if this were simply one more thing about diamonds that I needed to learn. Which, I suppose, it was.

Sierra Leone [see-AIR-ah lee-OHN] is a small country on the west coast of Africa, he said. Green. Very wet. Mountains near the sea, and a great harbour, one of the best in the world, where the British once brought ships full of freed slaves to start a new life. That is where the capital got its name: Freetown.

In the east, far from the sea, in the forest, is Kono. And in the 1930s, a British survey team found that the gravel in the riverbeds of Kono was full of diamonds. Not deep in pipes of rock, the way they are in South Africa. Near the surface. Washed out of the old pipes over millions of years and spread through the rivers and the swamps. A man with a shovel and a sieve could find them. A boy could find them.

"So everybody came," Elias said.

His grandfather was one of them. The Lebanese had been in Sierra Leone since the end of the nineteenth century, he said, traders, mostly from the villages in the south of Lebanon, who had left home poor and found a country where a man with a shop could make a living. They sold cloth and rice and tins and kerosene. When the diamonds were found, they bought diamonds too. They had the cash and the scales and the connections to Antwerp. By the time Elias was born, in a house behind his father's shop in the main town of Kono, the Lebanese families bought most of the diamonds that came out of that ground.

"I could weigh a stone before I could read," he said. "My father put them in my hand, at night, after the shop closed. *Feel it. How much?* I learned the carats the way other boys learned the names of football players."

He came to Antwerp at twenty-six, in the 1970s, to learn to cut. He stayed. He did not go back for twenty years.

Then he told me about the war.

In 1991, he said, a rebel army came across the border from Liberia, the country to the east. It called itself the Revolutionary United Front. RUF. It said it was fighting a corrupt government, and the government was corrupt, but that was not what the war was about for long. Within a few years the war was about Kono. Whoever held the diamond fields had money. Whoever had money had guns. The rebels took the fields and dug them with forced labour, men and boys at gunpoint, and smuggled the stones east across the border, where the president of Liberia, a man named Charles Taylor, traded them for weapons and sent the weapons back.

"Diamonds for guns," Elias said. "Guns for diamonds. A wheel. It turned for eleven years."

About fifty thousand people died, he said. Perhaps more. Nobody counted properly. Two million were driven from their homes, almost half the country. And the rebels did something else, something that the world remembered when it had forgotten everything else about that war.

They cut off people's hands.

He said it in exactly the same voice. I want you to know that. He did not lower it. He did not look away. He said *they cut off people's hands* the way he said *a carat is a fifth of a gram*.

They did it to terrify, he said. To stop people voting, in the election of 1996, because you vote with your hand, and a man with no hand cannot vote. They did it to punish villages. They did it, after a while, because they had always done it, and the boys who did it were boys, ten and twelve and fourteen, drugged and given machetes. They did it to men, to women, to old people, to babies.

And they had a question they asked first.

"Short sleeves," Elias said, "or long sleeves?"

I did not understand.

"Long sleeves," he said, and he touched his own wrist, very lightly, with two fingers of the other hand. "Short sleeves." He touched the

inside of his elbow. "They asked you to choose. As a joke. Where to cut."

I put my glass down on the table. My hand was not steady.

I want to stop here for a moment, outside the story, and say plainly that this was real. The war in Sierra Leone lasted from 1991 to 2002. The amputations happened, in their thousands, and the question about sleeves was asked, and survivors have told it, many times, to anyone who would listen. The stones that paid for it came to be called *blood diamonds*, or *conflict diamonds*, and a great many of them, Elias said, passed through the few streets beside Antwerp's railway station, through rooms like the one I was sitting in, and into rings in shop windows around the world.

"The world found out," Elias said. "Journalists. Films. Reports. It was bad for business. So the trade and the governments came together, in a town called Kimberley in South Africa, the same Kimberley as the rock, and made a promise."

The Kimberley Process [KIM-ber-lee], it was called. It began in 2003. Every parcel of rough diamonds that crosses a border must travel with a government certificate saying it did not come from a rebel war. A country that will not sign is shut out of the trade.

"And did it work?"

He considered this for a while, honestly, as he considered a stone.

"Partly," he said. "It made it harder. It also made it cleaner on paper than it is in the ground. The certificate follows the parcel. Not the stone. A parcel is a hundred stones, a thousand, from many mines, mixed. And the promise only speaks of rebels. If a government's own soldiers do the same thing, with the same machetes, the stones are clean." He shrugged. "Diamonds are very small. Borders are very long. A stone can walk across a border in a man's mouth and become a different country's stone."

I asked him then. I had to.

"Where were you," I said. "In those years. In the war."

He looked at me for a long time across the table, the way he had looked at me on the first morning in his doorway.

"Buying," he said.

He got up and went back to his wheel and turned it on, and the room filled with its sound like breath, and that was the end of the lesson.

I sat at the lathe with the grey dust on my fingers. I thought about the Kono stone, on the top shelf of the safe, in its soft grey cloth, bought in 1999, the year the rebels burned half of Freetown. I thought about it for perhaps a minute.

Then I put it in the place where things wait, and turned the lathe back on, and went on grinding my wife.

## **The Wheel**

The polishing wheel is called a *scaife* [SKAYF].

It is a flat, heavy disc of cast iron, about as wide as a dinner plate, mounted flat on a spindle like a record player, and it turns very fast, about three thousand times a minute. It is so well balanced that, spinning at full speed, it seems to stand still, and the only way to know it is moving is the sound, like breathing, and the faint cold wind it makes against your face.

The surface of the iron is scored with tiny lines, too fine to see, and into those lines the cutter rubs a paste of diamond dust and olive oil. That is what the oil from the shop across the river was for. That is the dust that falls from the lathe. Diamond, ground to powder, put back on iron, to grind more diamond. Nothing in the trade is wasted.

To polish a face onto a stone, a *facet* [FA-set], you lock the stone into a clamp on the end of a heavy arm, and you lower it, very gently, onto the spinning iron at exactly the angle you want. And you hold it there. Five seconds. Ten. Then you lift it, and look at it through the loupe, and lower it again. Hundreds of times for each face. A round stone has fifty-seven of them.

"The wheel does not care," Elias said, the first time I sat at it. "Remember that. Not about the stone. Not about you. It is turning

three thousand times a minute and it cannot stop for anything. If you put your hand on it, it will polish your hand."

It happened in the second winter, in the month of Dey again, almost exactly a year after I came.

I had been awake for, I think, thirty hours. I had started the first facets on her, the first real ones, the large flat face on the top of a diamond that the trade calls the *table*, because it is flat like a table and it is where the light comes in. It was going well. It was going better than anything had gone in my life. The face was coming up out of the yellow stone like a window being cleaned, and every time I lifted the arm and looked through the loupe, it was a little clearer, a little more open, and I could see a little further in.

I reached across the wheel to adjust the clamp. I had done it a thousand times. My hand knew the way.

My hand was tired. It went a centimetre too low.

I did not feel it at first. That is what everyone says, and it is true. There was a sound, a short high hiss, like a match being struck. Then there was a spray of something across the white cloth on the next bench. It took me a moment to understand that it was red.

Then I felt it.

I looked down at my left hand. The tip of my first finger was not there. The top of it, from the nail down, had been polished away. It was very clean. Very flat. A small, bright, perfect facet, wet and red, where the end of my finger had been.

I remember thinking, very clearly, very calmly: *that's a good angle*.

Then I sat down on the floor.

Elias turned off his wheel. He came over, without hurrying, and knelt beside me, which I had never seen him do. He took my wrist in one hand and lifted it above my head and held it there, firmly, the way you hold the string of a balloon. With his other hand he took a clean white cloth from the bench and folded it into a pad and pressed it hard against the end of my finger.

"Breathe," he said.

I breathed. The room went bright and then dim and then bright again.

"The stone," I said.

"The stone is fine," he said. "You lifted your hand. Your hand knew, even if you did not." He held the pad tighter. "You have given the wheel something. Now it will leave you alone for a while."

He took me to the hospital in a taxi. It was a big modern hospital on the edge of the city, and it was nearly midnight, and a tired young doctor with a shaved head cleaned the end of my finger and looked at it under a bright lamp and asked, in good English, what had happened.

I told him. He nodded slowly.

"It's very clean," he said. "Usually with machine injuries it's a mess. This is like a surgeon."

"It's a polishing wheel," I said.

"For what?"

"Diamonds."

He looked up at me, and then at Elias, who was standing in the doorway in his overcoat, very straight, with his hands folded in front of him. Something in the doctor's face changed. I think he had grown up in the city. I think he knew what that street was.

He stitched the skin over the end. There was not enough left to save the nail. The tip of my left forefinger would be about the width of a matchstick shorter, for the rest of my life, and numb, and very slightly flat.

"No work for two weeks," he said.

I was back at the wheel the next morning.

Elias made the tea. He looked at the bandage on my finger, and at my face, and at the clock on the wall, which said a quarter past six.

"Two weeks, the doctor said," he said.

"I know."

He nodded, as if that settled something. Then he handed me a thin cotton glove, the kind jewellers wear, with the first finger cut off at the second knuckle. He had cut it himself, that morning, before I came. It fitted perfectly.

"Now your hands have paid something," he said. "That is good. A cutter who has not paid always thinks the stone belongs to him."

I called home that weekend. My mother saw the bandage before I could hide it. She put her hand over her mouth.

"What did you do?"

"It's nothing. A small cut."

Kaveh pushed his face close to the screen. "Show me," he said.

I did not want to. He insisted. In the end I held up my hand to the camera and slowly unwound the bandage, and showed him the stitched, flat, strange end of my finger.

He looked at it for a long time, very seriously, his one eye close to the screen.

"It's shorter," he said.

"A little."

"How much?"

"About this much." I showed him with my other thumb and finger. The width of a matchstick.

He nodded. Then he climbed down off the stool, and I heard him go to the drawer where my mother kept the kitchen things, and come back, and climb up again. He was holding the measuring tape Roxana used for her clay.

"Hold it next to the other one," he said. "So I can see the difference."

I held my two hands up to the camera, side by side, and my son, who had been ten for nearly a year, I realised, ten, I had missed it, I had sent money, I had missed it, held a tape measure up to the

screen in Topanga and measured, very carefully, with his lips moving, what I had given to the wheel.

### **Inside the Stone**

I want to tell you now about the night I went inside her.

I know what it was. I want to say that first, plainly, so you will not think I am asking you to believe in something. I had slept perhaps four hours in three days. I had spent most of those days with one eye pressed to a loupe, staring into a small field of light that did not change. There is a name for what that does to the mind. Scientists call it the Ganzfeld [GANTS-felt] effect, from the German for *whole field*. When the eyes see nothing but an even, unchanging field of light for long enough, the brain grows restless for something to look at, and begins to make things up. Shapes. Faces. Places. And a grieving mind, as I have said, goes on drawing the person it has lost, out of habit, long after they are gone.

I know all that. I knew it then. I am not telling you what it was. I am telling you what it was like.

It was perhaps three in the morning. The workshop was dark except for the lamp over the table and the faint grey of the city through the north windows. Elias was at his wheel, at the far end, in the dark, still. I could not hear him breathing. I could not hear the wheel. Perhaps it was off.

I had her in the tweezers under the lamp, with the loupe to my eye, and I was looking through the new table, the clean window I had polished onto her top, down into her.

You must understand what is inside a diamond. Even a fine one. Under a loupe, at ten times, it is not empty. It is full of small things that were trapped in it while it grew, a billion years ago, in the dark, under the weight. The trade has names for them, and the names are beautiful, and I had learned them all.

A *feather* is a crack, a tiny one, flat and white and frayed at the edges, like a real feather frozen in ice. A *cloud* is a haze of dots too small to see one by one, like breath on glass. A *needle* is a long, thin

crystal of something else, lying in the diamond like a pin. A *pinpoint* is a single tiny speck of light, or dark, all alone.

She had all of them. I knew each one. I had named them in my notebook, every one, the way you name stars.

And that night, as I looked, they began to move.

Not much. Slowly. The way the lights of a city move when you look down on it from a plane at night, and the plane is turning, and the whole grid of lights wheels very slowly under you.

The feathers were streets. I could see that now. Long white streets, frayed at the edges, going down into the yellow dark. The clouds were the glow of districts I could not see, beyond the hills, like the orange haze over Los Angeles from the Crest road. The needles were the long straight roads between them. And the pinpoints were windows, single lit windows, in houses far away.

And I went in.

I do not know how else to say it. I was at the table with the loupe to my eye, and I was also walking down one of the white streets, in a soft yellow light like late afternoon, the light on a wall at the end of a summer day. It was very quiet. There was no wind. My footsteps made no sound.

I walked for a long time. Down the feather, along a needle, toward a pinpoint. A window. A lit window, in a small low house at the end of a long road.

She was in the window.

Roxana was standing at a counter, with her back to me, the way she had stood in our kitchen on the ninth night. In my old university sweatshirt. Her hair tied up with a pencil. She was looking down at something in her hands.

I said her name.

She turned round. She was annoyed with me. That was the first thing, and it was so exactly her that I nearly laughed. Not angry. Annoyed, the way she was when I came home at three in the

morning from a season and found her waiting up, with clay still drying on her arms.

"You're doing it again," she said.

"Doing what?"

"Looking for the crack." She held up the thing in her hands. It was the grey-blue bowl. She turned it over, the way she had turned it over in the warehouse in Venice, to show me the foot. "There's one in here too. You'll never find it. You never do."

"I'm making you something," I said. "I'm making you into something that lasts."

She looked at me with her head on one side. Then she put the bowl down on the counter, very gently, the way she put down everything she had made.

"Kian," she said. "I told you where I wanted to go."

"Where?"

"I *told* you." She was more annoyed now. "On the beach. You said *mm*."

I could not remember. I stood in the soft yellow light in the window of the small house at the end of the white road, and I tried and tried, and I could not find it anywhere.

She looked around the room then. Slowly. At the walls, at the counter, at the window, at the soft yellow light. As if she had only just noticed where she was.

And she said a strange thing. I have thought about it more than anything else she said that night.

"Whose house is this?" she said. "This isn't my house."

Then she was gone, and the window was gone, and I was at the table under the lamp with the loupe pressed to my eye so hard it had left a ring of bruise around the socket that lasted a week. My face was wet. The tweezers had slipped. The stone was on the felt, lying on its side, very small and very yellow, with the lamp shining into her new window.

At the far end of the room, in the dark, Elias was sitting at his wheel, turned round on his stool. He was watching me. I do not know how long he had been watching.

"You went in," he said.

It was not a question.

"I saw her," I said. "She was in there."

He was silent for a long time.

"People see many things in stones," he said at last. "At four in the morning, they see everything. It is the eye, and it is the mind, and it is grief." He stood up and turned on the light over the sink. "Go home. Sleep. You will not cut well today."

I went back to my room and slept for fourteen hours, the longest I had slept since Pasadena. When I woke the light was going and I had missed a whole day at the workshop, and the first thing I thought was not of Roxana, or of my children, or of the window in the stone.

It was of what she had said.

*This isn't my house.*

I put it down to grief. To the eye and the mind. To the Ganzfeld effect, and four hours of sleep in three days, and to the way a grieving mind goes on drawing the person it has lost, out of habit, and gets the details wrong.

That is what I put it down to. I wrote it down that night, so I would not forget. I have the page still.

## **Two Obsessives**

After that night, he began to talk to me.

Not much. Not every day. But sometimes, late, after the north light had gone and the city outside had turned on its own lights, he would turn off his wheel and make the tea and sit down across the long table from me, and we would talk. Or he would talk, a little, and I would listen.

I think, now, that he was deciding something. At the time I thought he had simply begun to like me.

"You have it too," I said to him once. "The engine."

He did not ask what I meant. I had told him, in pieces, over the months. The basement. The cube. The seasons on the fridge.

"Yes," he said.

"When did it start?"

"In my father's hand," he said. "The first stone he put in mine, at night, after the shop closed. I was four or five. *Feel it. How much?* I felt it. And the whole world went quiet." He turned his tea glass slowly on the table. "I have been inside that quiet for seventy-five years."

"Did you ever have seasons? Did it ever move on to something else?"

"No." He looked almost sorry for me. "That is the difference between us. Your engine is hungry. It eats a thing and moves on and is hungry again. Mine found what it wanted at five years old and never let go."

He had been married once. He told me that on another night, in the same flat voice.

"For eleven years," he said. "A good woman. From Beirut. She left me when I was forty."

"Why?"

"She said I looked at her the way I look at a stone." He drank his tea. "She meant it as a complaint. I took it as the greatest compliment I knew how to give. That was the problem."

I laughed. I could not help it. He did not laugh, but something at the corner of his mouth moved.

"Roxana never left," I said.

"No," he said. "She studied you instead. She wrote you on the wall of the kitchen. She found a way to live beside it." He was quiet for a while. "That is very rare. You should know how rare. Most of the

people who love men like us are like my wife. They wait, and then they leave, and they are right to leave. The ones who stay," he said, "pay more."

"What about dead air?" I asked him one night. "When you finish a stone. When it's done. The emptiness."

"I do not have it," he said.

"Everyone has it. If they have the engine."

He was silent for so long I thought he would not answer. Then he glanced, very briefly, toward the far end of the room, toward the tall green safe in the wall.

"I keep one stone uncut," he said. "That is the answer. As long as there is one stone in front of me that I have not cut, there is always something. The quiet never ends, because the work never ends." He turned back to me. "A man who finishes everything has nowhere to stand."

I thought about that for a long time. I thought about the Rubik's cube, given away to a boy in my class. The chess books returned to the library. The firm, sold. The mirror in its box in the garage, never used. The car, on the back of a truck.

"So you'll never cut the Kono stone," I said.

He looked at me. It was the long look. The look from the first morning.

"I will cut it," he said, "when I am ready to stop."

On the last of those nights, near the end of the second winter, he said the thing I have kept with me longest.

I had asked him whether he thought it could be cured. The engine. Whether there was a way to turn it off. I told him I had tried, at different times in my life, everything. Therapy. Medicines. Meditation, which I had made into a season, which had made Roxana laugh until she had to sit on the kitchen floor.

He shook his head.

"There is no cure," he said. "Not for us. The engine is not a disease. It is the shape of the stone. It was pressed into you, in the dark, before you knew you were anything. You cannot polish it out. You will only break."

"So what do you do?"

"You choose." He put his glass down. "We never stop wanting, Kian. We only learn to choose what we want. That is all the wisdom there is, for men like us. That is the whole of it. It took me seventy years."

"What did you choose?"

He did not answer that. He looked at the safe again. Then he looked at the stone on the felt between us, the yellow one, the one I had been planning and grinding for half a year and polishing for two months, the one with my wife inside it. He looked at it for a long time.

"Something I could not finish," he said.

## **One Sentence**

The call came on a Sunday, in the spring, a year and a quarter after I left.

My mother had called first, on her own, the day before. She did not usually do that. She called me in the middle of the afternoon, which was the middle of my night, and when I answered, half asleep on the narrow bed, she did not say anything for a moment. I could hear her breathing.

"It's Kaveh," she said.

He had stopped building, she told me. That had been months ago. He had taken apart every Lego model he owned, the castle, the ship, the space station he had built with his mother the Christmas before the accident, and sorted every piece. He had sorted them first into the ice-cube trays, and then into jars, because there were not enough trays. Glass jars from the kitchen, from the garage, from the neighbours. He had forty-one of them now, lined up along the wall of his room in a row, by colour, from white through the reds

and yellows and greens and the three blues to the dark bluish grey and black.

He did not build anything with them. He checked them. Every night, before bed, he went down the row with his lips moving, jar by jar, and checked that every piece was in the right one.

"And if one is wrong," my mother said, "he screams."

Not a tantrum, she said. The scream from Nowruz. The scream of pain. If one red brick was in the orange jar, he would scream until he could not breathe, until his face went dark, until he made himself sick on the carpet. Then he would find the brick and move it and check all forty-one jars again from the beginning. It took an hour, sometimes. Then he would go to bed.

"His teacher called me," my mother said. "He doesn't talk in class now. At all. He sits and he does the work, perfectly. Every letter. And he doesn't say anything. The teacher asked me if there had been a death in the family." She stopped. "I told her yes. She asked me if his father was involved in his care. I didn't know what to say to her, Kian."

I lay on the bed in the dark with the phone against my ear. The trams were going round the station square. I could feel my heart.

"I'll talk to him," I said.

"He doesn't need talking to," she said. "He needs his father in the room. I have watched this before. I watched it in a basement in Tehran with an exercise book. I watched it in Westwood with a dictionary. I know exactly what it is." Her voice broke, just a little, and then came back. "And I am seventy-two years old, and I cannot do this a second time on my own."

I booked a flight that night. I want that written down. I sat up on the narrow bed with my laptop and I booked it, Brussels to Los Angeles, the Thursday. I paid for it. I got the confirmation email. I lay back down and looked at the ceiling, and for a few hours I felt clean.

In the morning I went to the workshop.

I had planned to tell Elias. I had planned exactly how. I would finish the morning's facets, the next two on the lower half of the stone, and then I would tell him at noon, while he ate his apple, that I was going home for two weeks, and that I would come back.

I sat down at the wheel. I locked her into the clamp. I lowered her onto the iron.

And I knew, as soon as the facet touched the wheel, that I could not go.

I want to explain why, in the language of the trade, because it is the only way I can explain it at all. She was at the hardest point. The lower facets were half-cut. Their angles had to meet the upper ones exactly, to a fraction of a degree, or the light would not come back out of her. It would leak away through the bottom of the stone like water through a cracked bowl. I had the angles in my hands now. Not in my notes. In my hands, in the muscles of my fingers and my wrist, from three weeks of work. If I left for two weeks, I would lose them. I would come back and my hands would have forgotten, and I would have to find them again, and I might not.

That is what I told myself. I believed it. It was even true.

It was also the engine. I knew that too. I knew both things at once.

I cancelled the flight at noon, standing in the corridor outside the workshop, while Elias ate his apple at the window. It took four minutes. The airline gave me a credit for a future journey.

On Sunday Sahar called.

Not my mother. Sahar. Her own phone. Her own name on my screen, for the first time since I left. I was at the workshop. It was the middle of the afternoon in Antwerp and the early morning in Topanga, and she must have been awake all night, the way she was always awake at two in the morning, that summer, before.

I answered so fast I nearly dropped the phone.

She did not turn on her camera. The screen was black. I could hear her breathing, and behind it, very faintly, the sound of the canyon wind against the kitchen window.

"Sahar," I said. "Sweetheart. I'm so glad you—"

"Grandma said you were coming home on Thursday," she said.

Her voice was very calm. She was sixteen. She sounded much older.

"I was. I am. I mean—" I stopped. "Something came up. With the stone. I have to finish this part, or—"

She did not let me finish. She said one sentence, very quietly and very clearly, as if she had written it down beforehand and was reading it out.

"She isn't yours to finish."

Then she hung up.

I sat at the wheel with the phone in my hand for a long time. The scaife turned in front of me, three thousand times a minute, so fast it seemed to stand still. My wife was in the clamp above it, half-cut, with the north light going into her and coming back the colour of honey.

Elias was at his own wheel at the far end of the room. He had not turned round. But his wheel had stopped. The room was silent except for mine.

I thought about what my daughter had said. I thought about it very hard. I turned it over the way I turned a stone under the lamp. I understood every word of it. I understood exactly what she meant.

And then I lowered the stone back onto the wheel, and went on with the lower facets, because the light was going, and the angles were in my hands, and if I stopped now I might lose them.

I want you to know that I chose it. Not the engine. Not the stone. Not grief. Me. I sat at that wheel with my daughter's sentence in my ears and my son's forty-one jars in my mind and my mother's voice saying *I cannot do this a second time on my own*, and I made a choice, with my eyes open, the way Elias had said we must.

I chose the stone.

That is the lowest place in this book. I am telling you so you know it was a place, and that I walked there myself.

At the other end of the room, very quietly, Elias turned his wheel back on.



### **The Boy Who Swallowed the Stone**

*This is a story they tell in Kono, in the east of Sierra Leone, among the diggers. It is told about a boy, in the last year of the war. It may have happened once. It may have happened to many boys. The diggers do not say.*

*The boy was twelve, and he dug for the soldiers. They had taken him from his village with the other boys, and given them each a shovel and a sieve, and put them in a long pit by the river, and stood over them with guns. The boys dug the gravel and washed it in the river in round wooden sieves, swirling them the way you swirl rice, and the diamonds, which are heavy, sank to the middle of the sieve. And when a boy found one he had to hold it up in the air and shout, and a soldier would come and take it.*

*The boys were not allowed to put their hands near their mouths. Not to wipe their faces. Not to cough. A boy who put his hand to his mouth was beaten. A boy who put his hand to his mouth twice was taken away.*

*One afternoon this boy, swirling his sieve, saw a stone in the middle of the gravel that was bigger than any he had seen. It was the size of a pigeon's egg, and it was as clear as river water.*

*He did not hold it up. He did not shout. He did not put his hand to his mouth. He bent down to the sieve, the way you bend to drink from a river, and he put his face to the water, and took the stone into his mouth from the sieve with his lips, like a goat takes a leaf. And he swallowed it.*

*It went down hard. He thought it would kill him. It did not.*

*That night, in the hut where they slept, he lay awake with the stone inside him and he could feel it, the diggers say, like a second heart, beating slower than his own.*

*It took three days to pass through him. He hid it in the dirt floor of the hut. Then he waited for a chance, and in the confusion of a day when the soldiers were drinking, he ran. He ran three days through the forest with the stone in his mouth, and at the end of it he came to a town, and in the town under a mango tree there was a foreign man who bought stones and asked no questions.*

*The man looked at the stone a long time under his glass. He gave the boy more money than his whole village had seen in a year. The boy took the money and went to look for his mother.*

*That is the story. But the diggers always add something at the end, the old ones, the ones who have dug the longest. They say that a stone remembers. That it keeps the last thing it was given, the way a diamond keeps a feather in it from a billion years ago. That a stone held in the mouth of a frightened boy for three days keeps something of the boy forever, and that whoever owns it after, all their life, will sometimes taste river water and not know why.*

*And they say one more thing, and they say it very quietly.*

*They say that not every stone in Kono was swallowed. That some were paid for in other ways. And that the stones which were paid for in other ways remember those too.*

## **V. POLISHING**

## Tolkowsky

In the summer of the second year, with the lower facets done and the angles still in my hands, he taught me the mathematics of light.

He did it on paper. It was the only lesson he ever gave me with a pencil. He took a sheet of white card from a drawer, and a ruler, and a small brass protractor so old the numbers had worn off half of it, and he drew a diamond. Not from above, the way you see one in a ring. From the side, cut in half, like a slice through an apple.

It looked like a shallow hat sitting on top of a tall cone pointing down.

"The hat is the *crown*," he said. "The flat top of the hat is the *table*, where you have been working. The cone below is the *pavilion*. The thin edge where they meet, the brim of the hat, is the *girdle*. And the point of the cone, at the very bottom," he touched it with the pencil, "is the *culet* [KYOO-let]."

He drew a line coming down from above, into the table, like a ray of sunlight.

"Now," he said. "Where does it go?"

A man named Marcel Tolkowsky worked that out, he told me, in 1919.

He was born here, in Antwerp, in 1899, into a family of cutters, one of the old diamond families of the city. He grew up the way Elias grew up, with stones put into his hand before he could read. But he went to London to study engineering, and while he was there, at about twenty years old, he did a thing no cutter had done before. He sat down with a pencil and the laws of light, and he worked out, with mathematics, exactly what shape a diamond should be cut to send the most light back to your eye.

"Every cutter before him did it by eye," said Elias. "By feel. By what his father did. Some were geniuses. Most were not. Tolkowsky did the arithmetic. He wrote a small book about it. The whole trade has been arguing with that small book for a hundred years."

He drew the ray again. It came down through the table. It went into the stone. It hit the steep wall of the pavilion, on one side of the cone.

"Here is the secret," he said. "When light inside a diamond hits a wall at a steep enough angle, it cannot get out. It bounces back, the way your face bounces back from a dark window at night. Every time. Completely." He drew the ray bouncing off the wall, across the stone, to the other wall of the cone. "So it hits the other wall. And bounces again." He drew it. The line went up, out through the crown, toward the top of the page. "And comes back out. Toward your eye."

"So the shape is a trap."

"The shape is a trap. If the cone is too shallow, the light hits the walls too flat, and leaks out through the bottom of the stone. If the cone is too deep, the light bounces the wrong way and leaks out the sides. Either way, the stone is dark. Lifeless." He drew a shallow cone and a deep one, with lines leaking out of them like water from a bad bucket. "Tolkowsky found the angles in between. The pavilion at about forty-one degrees. The crown at about thirty-four. The table a little more than half as wide as the stone. And then light that goes in cannot find any way out except the one you want."

He put the pencil down.

"That is all a cutter does," he said. "He traps light. He builds a room with no way out but one, and he puts the light inside, and he waits until it gives up and comes home."

I looked at the drawing for a long time. I had been doing the angles for months without understanding them. Now I understood them, and I felt it catch, the old warmth, the engine taking hold of a new thing inside the old thing.

I could do this. I could do this perfectly. Here was something that could be calculated, exactly, to the degree, to the fraction of a degree. And then I would never have to guess about her again. She would be right, the way a solved equation is right, forever.

"Three things come back," Elias said, "when the cut is right. The trade has a name for each of them."

He wrote them on the card in his small upright hand.

*Brilliance*: the white light that comes back out of the stone, the brightness.

*Fire*: the colours. Because a diamond bends each colour of light a little differently, the way a glass prism does, so that white light going in comes out split into red and orange and blue and violet. Small flashes of rainbow. They call it fire.

*Scintillation* [sin-ti-LAY-shun]: the sparkle. The flicker of light and dark across the face of the stone when it moves, or you move, or the person wearing it breathes.

"Brilliance," he said, "fire, scintillation. Light, colour, life." He tapped the three words. "A stone that has all three is a stone that has been listened to."

I folded the card and put it in my pocket. I have it still. It is soft as cloth now at the folds.

## **Fifty-Seven**

A round diamond, cut the way Tolowsky worked out, has fifty-seven faces. Thirty-three on the crown, above the girdle. Twenty-four on the pavilion, below. Some cutters add a tiny flat face at the very point of the cone, the culet, and call it fifty-eight. Elias did not.

"A point should be a point," he said.

I had cut twenty-four of them by midsummer. The pavilion was done. Only the crown was left: the table, which was finished, and thirty-two smaller faces around it.

And it was at about this time that I began to give them names.

I want to explain this, because it was the strangest thing I did in Antwerp and, I think now, the only part of it that was not entirely the engine.

I had been cutting for eighteen months. I had cut the pavilion facet by facet, hundreds of touches on the wheel for each one, and I could not remember any of them. They had all blurred together, into one

long day at the wheel, the north light and the sound like breathing and the honey-coloured stone in the clamp. And it came to me one night, lying on the narrow bed above the wine shop, that when she was finished I would not be able to tell one face from another. They would be her. And none of them would be her. They would be fifty-seven pieces of nothing in particular.

So I decided that each of the thirty-two that were left would be for one memory.

One facet, one memory of Roxana. Before I touched the stone to the wheel each morning, I would choose a memory, and hold it in my mind, the whole of it, every detail, for as long as it took to cut that face. And that face would be that day. And when she was finished, I would be able to hold her up to the light and turn her, and know which face was which.

It was a ridiculous idea. I knew that. It was exactly the kind of idea Roxana would have written on the fridge in green marker, with a joke under it. *THE MEMORY SEASON. Thirty-two days. Bring tissues.*

I did it anyway.

The first was the bowl. The warehouse in Venice, the woman with clay on her arms and a pencil through her hair. *It's good enough. That's the best thing a bowl can be.* I cut that facet in four days. It is on the crown, on the left, if you hold her with the girdle facing you.

The second was the night she asked me what season it was, sitting up in bed with the sketchbook. The third was the calendar on the fridge, the first one, *Bring snacks*. The fourth was Big Sur, the photograph of the sea with no message.

The fifth was the hospital, the night Sahar was born, when she threw the stopwatch across the room.

I cut them through the summer and into the autumn. The wedding, and the violinist playing flat, and her hand pressing mine twice under the table. The night she closed my laptop on the spreadsheet and said *she's a baby, come and hold her*. The bread season. The bees.

By the twentieth I was slowing down. Not my hands. My mind. I had told myself there would be no trouble finding thirty-two memories of a woman I had lived with for sixteen years.

There was trouble.

I want to be honest about this, because it was a terrible thing to discover, and it is the centre of everything I have to tell you.

I had sixteen years with her. And I could not find enough memories.

Not because I had forgotten. Because I had not been there. I would reach for a summer, a Christmas, a birthday, and find nothing, or find a season instead. *The summer of the Latin season*. What did she do that summer? I did not know. I was learning Latin. *The year of the firm, the third year*. What was she like that year? What was she making? What did she worry about? I did not know. I was on the couch in the office three nights out of seven, eating the same turkey sandwich.

I had sixteen years of a calendar on the fridge, in her handwriting, describing me. I did not have sixteen years of her.

So I called my mother.

I did not tell her why. I said I wanted to hear about Roxana. My mother was quiet for so long on the line that I thought the call had dropped. Then she began to talk.

She told me that Roxana had called her every week, for sixteen years. Every Sunday. I had not known that. Roxana called her on Sunday afternoons, from the studio, while the kiln was firing, and they talked for an hour about nothing. About recipes. About my father's knees. About me.

"She called me at the start of every season," my mother said. "Every one. *It's started again*, she would say. *He's gone into the cube again*, she called it, because I told her about the cube. And we would talk about how long it might be, and what she would do. She kept a list of my recipes for when you forgot to eat. She asked me what you were like as a boy, so she would know what was coming."

"You never told me."

"You never asked." My mother's voice was gentle. "Kian, she was not waiting for you. You understand? She was not sitting at home waiting. She had a whole life going on beside you. She made a thousand bowls. She had friends you never met. She taught pottery to children at the library in the canyon on Saturdays, for nine years. Did you know that?"

I did not know that.

I sat on the edge of the narrow bed above the wine shop with the phone against my ear and the north light coming up grey over the station roof, and I listened to my mother tell me about my wife. A woman I did not know. A woman who taught children at the library on Saturday mornings while I was in the garage with a car.

I cut a facet for that. The twenty-first. The library. I had never seen it. I imagined it. It is on the crown, near the back.

Kaveh gave me a memory.

I asked him, on a call, if he would tell me something about his mother that I did not know. He thought about it for a long time, very seriously, with his one eye close to the screen.

"She used to sing in the car," he said. "When she drove me to school. She sang the same song every day. It was in Persian. She said her grandmother sang it to her."

"What song?"

He did not know the name. He tried to sing a little of it, in his high flat voice, and stopped, embarrassed. I did not know it. I had never heard her sing it. I had never driven him to school.

I cut a facet for the song. The twenty-sixth. I do not know the words. I cut it anyway.

I asked Sahar.

I wrote to her. A short message, carefully, at four in the morning. I said I was making something, and that I wanted to put into it things I did not know about her mother, and that she knew more than I did, and would she tell me one thing. Just one.

She did not answer for three days. Then she wrote back one line.

*No. Those are mine.*

By the end of the autumn I had thirty-one facets cut and named.

There was one left.

And I knew what it was. I had known for weeks. I had been saving it. Or avoiding it. I did not know which.

It was the beach at Zuma, the last summer. The sun going down. The children far out in the water, Sahar holding Kaveh flat on the surface the way her mother had once held her. The sea that grey-blue colour that goes almost black, like the bowl. And Roxana on the towel beside me, saying something to the sea.

And me, on my phone, reading about valve springs, saying *mm*.

That was the last memory. The last facet. I knew it as surely as I had known the grain of the first stone I ever split. And it was the only one of the thirty-two I could not see, because I had not been looking.

## **Fire**

I finished the crown, all but one face, on a grey afternoon at the end of the second autumn.

I took her off the wheel and out of the clamp and cleaned her in a small dish of alcohol, the way Elias had taught me, and dried her on a clean white cloth. Then I took the tweezers and lifted her up, and turned toward the north window.

I had looked at her through the loupe a thousand times as I worked. But that was looking at a part of her. One face, one angle, one flaw. I had not looked at the whole of her, the way you look at a finished thing. I had not let myself.

Now I did.

The light went in through the table.

And it did not come back out the way it went in. It came out changed. That is the only way I can say it. It went into the stone white, plain, the even colourless light of a north window on a grey day in Belgium. And it came back out at me in pieces. In flashes. In small sudden darts of colour, red, then orange, then a blue so pure it hurt, then violet, then gold, dancing across the faces of the crown as I turned her, very slightly, in the tweezers.

Fire.

I had read the word. I had written it on a card. I had understood the mathematics: the light bending, each colour by a different amount, splitting apart inside the stone like a choir breaking into its separate voices. I knew exactly why it was happening.

None of that had prepared me for it.

It was as if the stone were alive. As if there were something inside it, something small and bright, moving from room to room, turning on lights. Every time I moved my hand, a different room lit. Every time I breathed, the colours shifted. She was answering me. She was answering every movement I made with light.

I stood at the north window and held her up and turned her, slowly, and the fire moved in her, and I wept.

Not the way I had wept on the day she came, bent over the table with my closed hand against my forehead. This was quieter. It came up from somewhere very low and simply ran down my face, and I did not wipe it away, and I did not stop turning her.

Elias was at his wheel. He had turned it off.

He came and stood beside me at the window, and looked at the stone in the tweezers for a long time. He did not take her. He did not ask for the loupe. He simply looked, with his own eyes, from a little distance, the way you look at a painting in a gallery.

"Yes," he said.

I could not speak.

"You listened," he said. "That is not common. Most men who come to this trade never learn. They cut what they want to see. You cut what was there."

He was quiet for a moment.

"One more," he said. "The last face. Then she is finished."

"I know."

"Do you know which?"

"Yes."

He nodded. He looked at the stone a little longer. And then he did a thing he had not done in nearly two years, except to stop my bleeding. He put his hand on my shoulder. Lightly. For a moment. His hand was very thin, and very cold, and I could feel the bones of it through my shirt.

"Take a week," he said. "Before the last one. Sleep. Eat. Telephone your children. The stone will wait. It has waited a very long time already."

I did not understand what he meant by that. I thought he was talking about Roxana. About her death. About the two years.

He took his hand away and went back to his wheel and did not turn it on. He sat there, in the grey light, with his hands folded in his lap, looking at nothing.

### **Clearing the Shelves**

I did not take the week. Of course I did not. But I noticed, in the days that followed, that something in the workshop had changed, and it took me some time to understand what it was.

Elias was emptying it.

He did it slowly. Quietly. So gradually that I did not see it at first. A drawer of tools I had never seen him use, gone one morning, the drawer left empty and slightly open. The big magnifier on the end of the long table, gone. The jars of boart, all but my own, gone. The small electric heater that did very little, gone, so that the workshop was colder than ever and I worked in my coat.

Men came. Men I had never seen before, in long black coats or quiet suits, who buzzed at the steel door downstairs and climbed the four floors and sat with Elias at the long table for half an hour,

speaking in low voices in Dutch or French or Arabic, while I sat at my wheel and did not listen. Each one left with something. A paper of stones. A tool wrapped in cloth. Once, two of them carried out the second of the three wheels, iron bench and all, down the four flights of stairs, slowly, groaning, while Elias stood at the top and watched them go.

Every man who left shook my hand on the way out. Every one of them looked at me, quickly, the way you look at someone at a funeral when you do not know how they are related to the dead.

He stopped eating.

Not all at once. That was the thing. He still ate at noon, standing at the north window. But the flat bread got smaller. The white cheese went. The olives went. By the end of the first week it was only the apple. He still cut it into exact eighths with the small knife. He ate four of them. Then three. Then he ate one eighth, slowly, looking down into the street, and put the other seven back on the plate, and washed his hands at the sink for a long time.

He was very thin now. I had always thought of him as thin, but it had been the thinness of a man who has no use for anything extra. Now it was the other kind. His white shirt, still buttoned to the collar, stood away from his neck. His wrists, when he reached for the kettle, were like the handles of wooden spoons.

I asked him, finally, on a Thursday, when he put the seven eighths of apple back on the plate.

"Are you ill?"

He looked at me for a long time.

"I am eighty-one," he said. "That is not an illness. That is a number."

"You're not eating."

"I am eating what I need."

"You're giving everything away."

"I am giving back what was lent." He dried his hands. "Every tool in this room belonged to someone before me. Every stone that comes through that door belongs to someone after. A cutter owns nothing. He holds things for a while." He hung the towel on its hook, very straight. "I have held them long enough."

I did not know what to say. I said, "You told me you would never stop. That you keep one stone uncut, so there's always something in front of you."

"Yes."

"Then why—"

"Because I am almost finished," he said.

He said it simply, the way he said *a carat is a fifth of a gram*. Then he went back to his own wheel, by the north window, and sat down, and did not turn it on.

That night I did a thing I had not done in nearly two years. I lay on the narrow bed above the wine shop and I did not think about the stone.

I thought about Elias. About his thin wrists and his white shirt and his seven eighths of apple. About the men in black coats carrying the wheel down the stairs. About *I am almost finished*.

And I thought, for the first time, about the green safe, and the top shelf, and the soft grey fold of cloth that had sat there for twenty-eight years now. I thought: *he is giving away everything else. He has not given that away.*

I thought: *he said he would cut it when he was ready to stop.*

I lay there for a long time with that.

Then I put it in the place where things wait, and planned the last facet.

### **The Last Facet**

I cut it in the middle of Dey. The month that falls in the deep of winter. Two years, almost to the day, from the morning I came out of the central station into the hanging rain with one bag.

It was a small facet. One of the eight little triangles that sit around the edge of the table, the ones the trade calls *stars*. It should have taken a day. It took six.

I held the memory every hour of every one of those days. The beach at Zuma. The children far out in the water. The sun. The sea going grey-blue, almost black. Roxana beside me on the towel. Her voice, saying something to the sea. Me, on my phone, saying *mm*.

I tried, as I cut, to hear what she had said.

I could not. I knew the shape of it. I knew it was about the sea, and about Sahar, and about going. But the words had gone into the part of my mind where things go in and do not come out, and they had not come out, and they would not come out now, however long I held the stone to the wheel.

So I cut the facet for the thing I had not heard. It was the only thing I could do.

On the sixth day, at about eleven in the morning, I lifted the arm, and took her out of the clamp, and cleaned her in the alcohol, and dried her on the white cloth, and looked at her through the loupe for the last time.

Fifty-seven faces. Every angle where Tolkowsky had said it should be. The light going in through the table and finding no way out but one, and coming home, in fire.

She was finished.

I want to tell you what that felt like, exactly, because it is the last time in this book I will feel it.

It was warm water through the whole of my body. It was the twenty-ninth night of the cube, and the last move in San Diego, and the engine catching in the garage with the bags spinning on their wires. It was every summit I had ever reached, all of them at once, and this one higher than any of them, because this one had cost more than all of them together. A finger. Two years. A daughter's voice on a black screen.

I stood at the north window and held her up to the light. The first perfect thing I had ever made with my hands. I held my wife in the tweezers, and she was on fire.

It lasted about four minutes.

Then it was gone. And something else came in behind it.

I knew it at once. I had known it all my life. The silence after a station stops broadcasting. Dead air.

I had thought, somehow, that it would not come this time. That this was different. That this was not a season but the end of seasons, the last thing, the one that would fill the hole for good. I had thought, without ever quite saying it to myself, that when she was finished I would be finished too, and I would be able to stop.

It came within the hour.

I sat at the wheel with her on the white cloth in front of me, finished, perfect, on fire in the north light. And I felt the engine go on running, with nothing in front of it. The hum of it in my chest. The restlessness in my hands. The terrible empty loud quiet.

And then I felt it begin to look for the next thing.

I want to put this down plainly. I want you to see it exactly, because it is the most frightening thing I know about my own mind, and it happened in that room, on that day, with my wife's stone on the cloth in front of me.

Within the hour, before the warmth was even fully gone, I found myself looking at the green safe in the wall.

At the top shelf. At the grey fold of cloth.

And I thought, quite clearly, not in grief, not in horror, but with the old warm curiosity rising in me like water in a well:

*I wonder what the Kono stone looks like inside.*

I looked away from the safe. I made myself. I looked down at her on the cloth.

When I looked up, Elias was watching me from his chair by the north window. He had been watching me, I think, the whole time. He had seen where my eyes went. He had seen what was in them.

His face did not change. He looked at me for a long time, the way he had looked at me on the first morning, from my shoes to my hair. Then he nodded, once, very slowly, the way a man nods when a stone does exactly what he knew it would do.

"Wrap her," he said. "Put her on the table. Go home."

"It's eleven in the morning."

"Go home. Sleep. Eat something." He paused. "Come tomorrow at eight. Not before. Eight."

I looked at him.

"I have three things to tell you," he said. "I will tell you each of them once."

**Forever**

*In the spring of 1947, a young woman named Frances Gerety [GERR-uh-tee] sat up late in her office in Philadelphia, trying to write one sentence.*

*She was a copywriter at an advertising agency, and her client was the biggest diamond company in the world, a company from South Africa that owned or controlled most of the rough diamonds then being dug out of the earth. The company had a problem. Diamonds were not, in fact, rare. There were a great many of them. What kept them expensive was that the company kept most of them locked away, and released only a few at a time. And that only worked as long as people wanted them, and kept them, and never, ever sold them back.*

*So the company needed people to believe two things. That love required a diamond. And that a diamond, once bought, should never be let go.*

*Before the war, an engagement ring with a diamond in it had not been a common thing in America. The agency had spent nine years changing that. They had put diamonds on the hands of film stars. They had sent speakers into high schools to talk to girls about engagement rings. They had planted the idea in newspapers and magazines that a man should spend a month's wages on a stone, and later, two. It was working. But they still did not have a sentence.*

*Late that night, tired, about to go home, Frances Gerety wrote four words on a sheet of paper, almost as an afterthought.*

*A Diamond Is Forever.*

*She did not think much of it. She said so, later, many times. She thought it was all right. The agency used it the next morning. It has been used every year since.*

*Half a century later, a famous trade magazine named it the best advertising slogan of the twentieth century. By then it had done exactly what it was meant to do. A planet of people believed that love was a stone. That a stone was forever. That to let it go was to*

*let love go. They bought them, and wore them, and left them to their children, and almost never sold them back.*

*Frances Gerety never married. She lived in Philadelphia and worked at the agency for more than twenty-five years, writing sentences for the company's diamonds. Nobody ever gave her one to keep forever.*

*She died in 1999, the year the rebels burned half of Freetown.*

*A diamond, as anyone who has ever held one in a flame knows, is not forever. In a hot enough fire, with enough air, it burns. It glows red, then orange, then white. It shrinks. It leaves no ash and no mark. It turns, in a few minutes, into the same gas you breathe out.*

*The four words have lasted much longer than that.*

## **VI. INSPECTION**

### **The Man Who Bought a Hand**

*This one is not a folk tale. It has no once-upon-a-time and no moral at the end. It happened, in the spring of 1999, in the east of Sierra Leone, on a road outside the main town of Kono. It is told here plainly, because there is no other way to tell it.*

*A buyer drove out to that road in a white car. He was a Lebanese man, in his fifties, born in that town, the son and grandson of men who had bought diamonds there. He had come back from Europe for the stones. That year the stones were very cheap, because the war made them cheap, and a man with cash and a car and no questions could buy in a week what would have taken him a year in peacetime.*

*He had done it before. Many times. He was not a rebel and he did not carry a gun. He was a buyer. He drove out to a place he was told to drive to, and men came out of the trees, and they sat in the shade by the road and showed him stones, and he weighed them on a small brass scale he carried in a wooden box, and he paid in American dollars. Then he drove away. That is what buying was, that year, on that road.*

*On that day, the man who came out of the trees was a commander. He was very young, perhaps twenty, and he wore a woman's wig and a pair of mirrored sunglasses, and he was laughing. Behind him were boys with guns, and behind the boys, sitting in the dust at the edge of the road with his hands tied in front of him, was a child. A boy of nine or ten. From a village they had burned that morning.*

*The commander showed the buyer a stone.*

*It was the finest rough the buyer had seen in thirty years. The size of a fingernail. Rounded at the corners. The colour of honey held up to a window. He took out his loupe and looked into it, and for a minute, the way it always happened to him with a stone, the road and the trees and the boys with guns went quiet around him, and there was only the light going into the stone and coming back.*

*He asked the price.*

*The commander laughed. He said the price was already being paid. He said the buyer had come at a good time. The stone was a gift to*

him, the commander said, because the buyer was a friend of the revolution, and a friend should be shown what the revolution can do.

Then he turned to the boy in the dust, and called out a question, the question every person in that country had learned to fear.

*"Short sleeves, or long sleeves?"*

*The boy did not answer. He was too frightened to speak.*

*So the commander turned to the buyer, smiling behind his mirrored glasses, and asked him instead. "You choose," he said. "Friend. Short, or long?"*

*The buyer said nothing.*

*He did not say long. He did not say short. He did not say stop, or no, or I will not buy it, or I will give you everything in the car to let him go. He sat in the shade by the road with the stone in his hand and his loupe in the other, and he said nothing at all.*

*The commander laughed again. He said a man who will not choose has chosen. He said: "Long."*

*It was done in front of the buyer, at the edge of the road, with a machete. It took less time than it takes to tell. The boy made a sound the buyer heard every night for the rest of his life.*

*Then the commander folded the stone into the buyer's hand, and closed his fingers over it, and patted them.*

*The buyer drove away. He did not look in the mirror. He drove back to town and took the next flight to Europe with the stone in his pocket.*

*He never sold it. He never cut it. He kept it in a safe for twenty-eight years, in a fold of soft grey cloth, and told himself he was waiting for the right hands.*

*This is not a story about the boy. The boy has his own story, and it is his to tell, and he is alive. This is a story about a man who wanted one thing so much, for one minute, on a road in the shade, that he let the world go quiet around it.*

*And it is about what the world did, while he was not listening.*

### Three Things

I came at eight.

It was still dark. It is still dark at eight in Antwerp in the deep of winter. The street was empty. The young officer in the police booth lifted two fingers to me from behind the glass. I climbed the four floors, and pressed the grey button, and the steel door opened, and he was there.

He was not at his wheel. He was sitting at the long table, in his white shirt buttoned to the collar, with his hands flat on the wood in front of him. The workshop was almost empty now. The wheels were gone, except his. The jars were gone. The drawers stood open and bare. The green safe in the wall was open, too, and I could see from the doorway that every shelf was empty.

On the table in front of him, on a square of black felt, was the stone. My stone. Finished, on fire, catching the light of the lamp.

Beside it lay two envelopes. One was old and thick and creased, and its corners were soft from being handled. The other was new and thin.

He did not make tea.

"Sit down, Kian," he said. "Put the stone on the cloth."

It was already on the cloth. I sat down on the stool across from him. My hands were shaking and I did not know why.

"I am going to tell you three things," he said. "I will tell each of them once."

"The first thing is about carbon."

He looked at the stone on the felt, not at me.

"Carbon does not remember. It was a tree once, and then coal, and then a woman, and then a stone, and it never knew it was any of them. We are the ones who remember. We put the people we lose into things. A ring. A photograph. A stone. So that we never have to finish losing them."

He was quiet for a moment.

"That is not love. That is keeping. Love lets go. Keeping polishes."

"The second thing is about your daughter."

I felt it then. Something cold that started at the back of my neck and went down.

"She wrote to me," he said. "The week you came. She found my letter on your computer, on the kitchen table, where you had left it open. *Come. Bring nothing.* She found my address. She wrote me a letter by hand and sent it by post, and it came here eleven days after you did." He laid one finger on the old envelope. "She asked me to let her mother go."

I could not speak.

"But it was not mine to let go," he said. "A man can only give away what is his. Your wife was yours to give back to the sea. And you never would have done it with your eyes open. I knew that the first morning, when you stood in my door with your wet shoes and your broken wrist. I knew it from the letter. Every sentence the same length."

He looked at me then.

"So I let you do it with your eyes closed."

I did not understand. I want to tell you that honestly. For a moment I did not understand at all. I sat on the stool and looked at him and the words went past me like a car on the road below the house.

Then I understood.

"The lesson," I said. "The fire."

"Yes."

"The stone you gave me. In the tongs. The cheap lab stone. Worth nothing."

"Yes."

"That was—"

"That was your wife," said Elias. "The laboratory sent her here, as you asked. I signed for her. I sent you across the river for oil. When

you came back, I put a different stone on the felt and told you it was her. I kept her in my shirt pocket for three weeks, in a white paper, until you were ready. Then I put her in your hands, and you held her in the flame, and you watched her turn to light."

He did not look away.

"You said it was beautiful. You were right. It was the only goodbye you were able to make. So I made it possible."

I do not remember standing up. I remember that I was standing, and the stool was on its side on the floor behind me, and my hands were on the edge of the long table, gripping it, and the table was shaking because I was shaking.

"You burned her."

"No," he said. "You did. I held the torch."

"She was in your *pocket*. For three weeks. You walked around with her in your *shirt*—"

"Yes."

"I breathed her." I heard myself say it. "You said, *you are breathing some of it now*. I breathed her in. In this room."

"Yes," said Elias. "You did. She is in this room still. In your lungs, and mine, and the walls, and the rain. A little. That is where carbon goes. That is where all of us go, in the end." He folded his hands. "It was the kindest place I could think of. Kinder than a box. Kinder than a ring."

"Sit down," he said. "There is a third thing."

I did not sit down. He waited. He waited the way he had waited for my hands to learn to hold a stone, the way he waited for the light. In the end, I picked up the stool, and sat.

"The third thing," he said, "is about the Kono stone."

He looked at the stone on the felt between us. The yellow one. The honey-coloured one. The one I had worked on for two years. The one with my fingertip in it. The one with thirty-one memories in it, and one I could not see.

"For twenty-eight years I looked for clean hands to cut it," he said. "There are no clean hands, Kian. Not mine. Not yours. Not anyone's. So I chose hands that did not know."

I looked at the stone.

"A man who does not know what he is holding," said Elias, "cuts with love. That is all I needed from you. Your love. For two years. Pointed at the wrong stone."

I looked at it for a long time.

Fifty-seven faces. Every angle where Tolkowsky said it should be. The fire moving inside it from room to room, turning on lights.

*Whose house is this*, she had said, in the window, in the soft yellow light. *This isn't my house*.

The grey cloth on the top shelf of the safe, a finger's width to the left.

*Clean hands are only hands that do not know what they are holding.*  
*Short sleeves, or long sleeves?*

I had read the story the night before, in my room above the wine shop. Elias had left it for me on the long table when I went home at eleven, in an envelope with my name on it, typed, six pages. I had read it at midnight. I had thought it was about someone else.

"The man in the white car," I said.

"Yes," said Elias.

He did not say anything else for a while. Neither did I. The north window was going grey now, the first light coming up over the roofs of the diamond quarter, the first tram bell ringing far away round the station square.

"Why," I said at last. "Why not you. Why not cut it yourself, if you wanted it cut."

"Because I could not have cut it with love," he said. "I could only have cut it with what I felt on that road. And a stone cut that way would have been dark. You have seen a dark stone. The light leaks out of the bottom." He touched the felt beside it. "This one is not

dark. You made it beautiful. You made it the most beautiful stone I have seen come out of this street in fifty years. That is what it was owed."

"Owed."

"Yes. Owed." He looked at me steadily. "A thing that cost what it cost should not also be ugly. That would be two crimes."

"I did not do this to hurt you," he said.

He said it plainly, the way he said everything.

"I did it because it was true. Your wife wanted the sea. Your daughter wanted her mother back. The stone wanted a cutter. You wanted something to cut. I had all four in this room. I gave each of them what they asked for." He spread his thin hands on the table. "Two people asked me for something. I gave you both what you asked. That is not the same as hurting you. Most people go to their graves without learning the difference."

"And what did you want?"

He was silent for a long time.

"To stop," he said.

"Every stone carries one tension," he said. "I told you that on the first day. I said you would understand it on the last day and not before. This is the last day."

He looked at me with his very dark, very still eyes.

"Find it before you cut," he said, "or it finds you."

He pushed the old envelope across the table toward me, very slowly, with one finger.

"Yours," he said, "was never in the diamond."

## The Letter

The envelope was addressed in blue ink, in a girl's careful capitals, to *MR ELIAS KARAM*, at the address in the diamond quarter. The stamps were American. The postmark was from the town at the bottom of the canyon, two years before. It had been opened once, neatly, along the top, with a knife, and then closed again, and sealed with a strip of clear tape.

On the back, in the same blue ink, she had written: *Please give this to my father when he finishes. Not before.*

Inside were four pages torn from a school exercise book. The same kind I had kept under my pillow in a basement in Tehran.

And a second sheet, folded separately, newer, whiter, in a different pen. Elias pushed the thin envelope across to me too. "That one came last week," he said. "She sent it to be put in with the first. I did not read it."

I unfolded the four old pages. Somewhere in the last hour I had picked the stone up again. It was in my other hand. I did not know I was holding it until I read the first line.

*Baba,*

*If the man in Belgium does what I ask, you'll read this when your stone is finished. You'll probably be holding it.*

*Put it down. I mean it. Put it down first.*

I put it down. On the felt. My hand did it without me.

*I'm writing this on Mom's side of the bed, because it's the last place in the house that still smells like her. It's going. Every night there's a little less. Kaveh comes in around three and gets under the covers, and we lie there and breathe in turns, like we're stealing it from each other.*

*You took her on a Tuesday. I came home and went into the living room to say goodnight to her like I always did, and I picked up the box, and I knew right away, because it was lighter.*

*Do you know how I knew what it weighed? Because I'd been sleeping with it. Every night since they gave her back. I took it off the shelf after you went to bed and I slept with it under my arm, like I was five, and I put it back before you got up. Every night. You never noticed. You notice everything, Baba. You notice if a violin is a hair flat. You didn't notice that.*

*You opened her with Grandma's gold spoon. It was on the counter with grey on it. You didn't even wash it.*

*So I did something, and I'm telling you because you should know what you turned us into.*

*I put my finger in what was left of her, and I put it in my mouth.*

*It tasted like chalk and pennies and nothing. I did it again the next night. And the next. And the next. Until Grandma caught me, in the kitchen, at two in the morning, with my finger in my mouth and the box open on the counter, and she didn't shout. She sat down on the floor. She sat down right on the kitchen floor and cried so hard she couldn't get up, and I had to sit down with her, and we sat there on the tiles until it was light.*

*I wanted some of her somewhere you couldn't get a spoon into.*

*Some of her is in me now, Baba. You can't cut me.*

*Mom wanted the ocean. She said it on the beach at Zuma, that last summer, when I was teaching Kaveh to swim. I saw her from the water. I couldn't hear the words but I saw her look out at us and say something, and later in the car she told me. "Past the kelp," she said. "Where you learned to swim. That's where I want to go." She said she'd told you. You were right there. You were on your phone.*

*You never heard anything that wasn't a season.*

*Kaveh made a calendar on the fridge like Mom's. Just squares. He crosses one off every night before bed. He doesn't put a number at the bottom because he doesn't know how many there will be. He asked me how many there would be and I told him I didn't know, and he said, "Then I'll just keep drawing them."*

*He's stopped talking much. He's started sorting things. Everything. His Lego, his pencils, the spoons in the drawer. If something is in the wrong place he gets so upset he shakes. You know what that is. Mom knew what it was. Grandma knows. There's nobody left in this house who knows what to do about it.*

*He's yours, Baba. That's what Mom said at Nowruz. "He's yours." She said it like a weather report. She was right. He's yours, and you left him.*

*Now the car.*

*Nobody has ever said this to you. Grandma said don't. The lawyer said don't. The police said you were in shock. The therapist they sent me to said you'd get there when you were ready.*

*You never got there. You went to Belgium instead.*

*Mom texted me at 2:41 that night. I was awake, because you two were laughing so loud in the garage I could hear it through the floor. I still have it. I read it every day. I'm going to copy it exactly, so you can't say you don't remember.*

*"Dad's driving her first. He promised slow. Go to sleep monkey. Love you."*

*Mom never drove that car.*

*You never let anyone touch it.*

*You told me so yourself. In the garage. "Nobody drives it but me. Not even your mother."*

*You'd been awake for two days. She knew. That text is the last thing she ever said to me, and it says she knew, and she went anyway. Because she loved your seasons more than she loved being careful. Because it was the end of one and she wanted to be there for the end, the way she always was, so she could write Welcome back.*

*I hate her for that a little. I've never said that to anyone. I've never even said it to myself out loud. Now I've said it to you, so now you have to carry it too.*

*I'm going to write to the man in Belgium. I found his letter on your laptop. "Come. Bring nothing." You didn't even close it.*

*I'm going to ask him to let her go. I'm going to ask him to do to you what you did to us. Take her while you're not looking. I don't know if he will. I don't know what he can do. I don't want to know.*

*If he does it, then I did it. Not him. Me.*

*So hate me, Baba. But hate me exactly the right amount.*

*Not more.*

*I love you.*

*That's the worst part of this letter. I've been trying to stop since you left. Every day. I try to put it down like you put things down when a season ends. I can't. It's the one thing I can't put down.*

— S.

I sat at the long table with the four pages in my hands.

I could not see them any more. My eyes had stopped working. Elias had not moved. The north window had gone from grey to white. The tram bell rang again round the station square.

And the curve came back.

Not the curve the way I had remembered it for two years. Not her in the driver's seat, pulling it forward because she was shorter, laughing at how low it was, her bare feet on the pedals. That had never happened. I knew it, suddenly, the way you know the grain of a stone, all at once, without searching. It had never happened. I had built it. Facet by facet, in a hospital bed in Pasadena, because a man can build anything when he has to, and I had polished it until there was no scar on it at all.

What came back was this.

My hands on the wheel. The thin wooden wheel of a 1967 car, smooth under my palms. The keys in the ignition, where I had put them. Roxana beside me, in the passenger seat, in my old university sweatshirt, with her arm out of the window and the cold air pushing

against her hand. Singing something under her breath. The orange field of the city falling away below us. The stars coming out.

The forty hours.

How heavy my eyes were. How I was so happy, so warm, so finished, that I let them close. For one second. Only one. On a straight piece of road, before the curve, because the summit was behind me, because the season was done, because for the first time in three years I could rest.

The headlights sweeping across a wall of rock.

My hands gripping the wheel. Hard. Bracing. *You usually see it when someone's holding on to something hard.*

The bruise across my chest, from my left shoulder down to my right hip. The driver's belt.

The officer in the hospital, writing in his notebook, not looking at me.

My mother at the window, who did not turn around.

I folded the four pages, very slowly, along their old creases. My hands knew the way.

Then I opened the second sheet. The new one. The different pen.

*P.S. — Different pen. I'm seventeen now. Elias says you're nearly done.*

*He had forty-one jars by the end, Baba. Kaveh. Forty-one jars of Lego by colour along his wall, and if one piece was wrong he screamed until he threw up on the carpet. Every night. For a year. Grandma and I took turns sitting with him.*

*In October we scattered what you left of her. Past the kelp, at Zuma, where I learned to swim and where I taught him. We didn't wait for you. Grandma said we'd waited long enough.*

*Kaveh held her. The bag, in both hands. He wouldn't let anyone else. He held it so tight and so long his hands went white, and then he opened it and let go, all at once, and she went into the water, and he watched her go.*

*He doesn't sort the Lego anymore. He gave the jars to the library in the canyon, the one where Mom used to teach, so other kids could build things.*

*Now he counts waves.*

*He counted four hundred and twelve that day, and he wouldn't get back in the car until he'd finished. He goes every Saturday. Grandma drives him. He sits on the sand and counts until it gets dark.*

*He's eleven, Baba.*

*Come home before he learns how to leave.*

### **Arithmetic**

I do not know how long I sat there.

Long enough for the light to change twice. Long enough for the tram bell to ring many times. Long enough for my hands to stop shaking, and then start again, and then stop.

Elias did not move. He sat across the long table from me with his thin hands folded, and waited, the way he waited for everything. Once, he got up, slowly, and made tea in the two glasses after all, and put one in front of me, and sat back down. I did not drink it. It went cold.

"I want to hit you," I said at last.

"Then hit me," said Elias. "If it would help."

"Would it?"

"No." He looked at me. "It would only give you something to do. You have always needed something to do. That is how we came here."

I did not hit him.

"What happens to it," I said. "The stone."

He looked at it, on the felt between us, still burning in the white light from the window.

"It will be sold," he said. "This week. A man is coming on Thursday. It will fetch a great deal of money. More than anything else that has ever left this room."

"And you'll keep it."

"No." He shook his head very slightly. "I have found him."

"Found who?"

"The boy," said Elias. "From the road. He is a man now. Thirty-eight years old. He lives in Freetown. He has a wife, and two daughters, and a small shop where he repairs mobile telephones, with one hand. It took me nine years and a great deal of money to find him, and I found him six years ago, and I have known his name every day since." He was quiet for a moment. "Every cent the stone fetches will go to him. Through a lawyer, so he never has to see my face. He will not know where it came from. He will only know that one day his life changed."

"Is that justice?" I said.

Elias thought about it. He thought about it honestly, the way he thought about a stone, with all of his attention, for a long time.

"No," he said. "It is arithmetic."

He unfolded his hands and laid them flat on the table.

"There is no justice for what happened on that road," he said. "Nothing I do now can make it not have happened. Money does not grow a hand back. But a stone that cost a hand should not make a buyer rich. So the hand gets the stone. That is all. It is not forgiveness. It is not justice. It is only the numbers on both sides of the page coming out even." He looked at me. "I have been a buyer all my life, Kian. Arithmetic is the only honest thing I know how to do."

"You could have stopped it," I said. "On the road. You could have said something."

"Yes."

"Why didn't you?"

He was silent for a long time. Longer than for any other question I had asked him in two years. When he answered, it was in the same voice, flat and even. But it was quieter.

"Because I was looking at the stone," he said.

He looked down at his hands.

"I had my loupe to my eye, and the light was going into it, and the world went quiet. The way it goes quiet for you. The way it went quiet for you in the basement in Tehran with your exercise book, while your mother asked you to hold her hand. I heard the question. Short or long. I heard it. And I was looking at the stone, and the quiet was so beautiful, and I did not want to come out of it. That is the whole truth. There is no other part."

He raised his eyes to mine.

"There is a sentence every buyer on that road told himself," he said. "*If I do not buy it, someone else will.* It was true. It is still true. It is the sentence I have said to myself every night for twenty-eight years. And it is the sentence I will die with, because it is true, and it does not help at all."

I picked up the stone.

I held it up, one last time, to the north window. The fire moved inside it from room to room, turning on lights. Red. Orange. A blue so pure it hurt. Violet. Gold.

Fifty-seven faces. Thirty-one of them named for a woman who was not inside it. One named for a sentence I had never heard. And all of them cut, with love, into the price of a child's hand.

It was the most beautiful thing I had ever made.

I put it down on the felt. I pushed it, very gently, with one finger, across the table toward him.

"It's not mine," I said.

"No," said Elias. "It never was."

He stood up then. Slowly. It took him a long time. He was so thin now that his white shirt seemed to stand on its own around him. He

went to the north window and stood there looking down into the street, the way he had stood every day at noon with his apple.

"I will not see the spring," he said.

I did not ask him how he knew. I did not ask him if he was ill. I knew he was not ill. I knew exactly what he was. He was a man whose engine had found the one thing it wanted at five years old, and had held it for seventy-six years, and had at last, this morning, set it down.

*A man who finishes everything has nowhere to stand.*

*I will cut it when I am ready to stop.*

"You'll be alone," I said.

"I have always been alone," he said. "That is not the same as lonely. Men like us confuse the two all our lives." He turned his head and looked at me over his shoulder. "You are not alone. That is the difference between us. That is the only difference that matters. Go home."

"What if I can't?" I said. "What if I go home and it starts again. The engine. What if I stand in the door and I'm already looking for the next thing. I was looking for it yesterday. You saw me. Within the hour. I was looking at your safe."

"Yes," said Elias. "I saw."

"So what do I do?"

He turned back to the window.

"You choose," he said. "We never stop wanting. We only learn to choose what we want. I told you that. It took me seventy years and a child's hand to learn it. You have learned it in two years, and it cost you a fingertip and your wife and very nearly your children." He was quiet for a moment. "You got it cheaper than I did. Do not waste it."

I put on my coat.

I stood in the open steel doorway of the empty workshop for a moment, with my one bag over my shoulder, the way I had stood there on the first morning with my wet shoes. He was at the north

window with his back to me. The stone was on the felt on the long table, burning quietly in the morning light. The green safe stood open and empty in the wall.

"Elias," I said.

He did not turn round.

"Bring nothing," he said.

I went down the four flights of stairs, and out of the steel door, and past the cameras, and past the young officer in the booth, who lifted two fingers to me from behind the glass for the last time, and out between the steel posts into the street.

It was raining.

## **The Door**

The flight was eleven hours. I did not sleep. I did not read. I did not count anything.

I sat by the window with my hands in my lap, the left one with its short flat fingertip on top, and looked out at the white floor of cloud. And for the first time in my life, I let the dead air come.

I did not fight it. I did not look for something to put in front of it. I let it come in and fill me, the empty loud quiet, the engine running with nothing to hold, and I sat inside it, and I felt it, all of it, the whole terrible weight of a mind with nothing to do. For eleven hours.

It did not kill me. That surprised me. All my life I had believed it would.

I want to tell you that it was peaceful. It was not. Somewhere over Greenland the engine began, very quietly, to look for something. It went to the safe in Antwerp, and I brought it back. It went to the mathematics of light, and I brought it back. It went to the car, and how I could have taken the curve, and the exact angle of the steering wheel, and I brought it back. Again and again. Like a dog that keeps going to the door.

Every time, I brought it back to the same place. To a small sheet of exercise paper, taped to a fridge with too much tape, with squares drawn on it in pencil all the way down to the bottom edge.

I did not know if that was choosing. I thought it might be. I thought it might be the beginning of it.

My mother met me at the airport. She was smaller than I remembered. Older. She had driven herself, in her old car, the one she had refused to let me replace for fifteen years, and she was standing at the barrier in arrivals in her good coat, holding her handbag in front of her with both hands.

She saw me. She saw my face, and my hand, and the one bag over my shoulder, and nothing else in my arms.

She did not ask about the stone.

She put her arms around me, at the barrier, in front of everybody, and held on. She was shaking. She was saying something into my coat, very quietly, in Persian, the same thing over and over.

It was the sentence. The one from the kitchen two years ago, when she had found the spoon. The one that went past me like a car on the road below the house.

I heard it this time.

*Your father left the hole open, she was saying. Your father left the hole open. Your father left the hole open, Kian.*

We drove up the canyon in the late afternoon. Neither of us spoke. The oaks. The dirt road. The long low house at the end of it, with the view down toward the sea.

She did not park in front of the garage. She parked by the kitchen door.

In the hallway, on the floor, just inside the front door, there was a small carpet. A prayer rug. Old, faded, a hundred years old at least, with a garden pattern in red and walnut brown and the blue that is almost black. My father's rug from Tehran. My mother had brought it up from Encino and laid it there, in my house, sometime in the two years I had been gone.

In its corner, the hole.

I stood on it. I knelt down. I put my finger in the hole, the short flat one, and felt the edges of it, the old knots frayed and soft where they stopped.

I understood it then. Thirty years late.

A man who could mend a hundred-year-old carpet so that nobody could ever find the scar, and he left one hole open in his own rug. Not because he did not have the time. Because some holes are not damage. Some holes are the shape of what was there. Mend them perfectly, and the people who walk on it forget. A carpet, my father said, forgets nothing. It was the people he worried about.

He kept the hole so that he could put his finger in it, in America, and remember. Tehran. The shop. The bazaar. The basement. The war. Everything he could not bring. He did not make it into something else. He did not polish it. He let it be a hole, and he let it hurt, and he kept it near the door, where he would step on it every day.

I had spent two years trying to make my wife into a stone with no scar on it.

I stood up. My knees ached. My mother was standing behind me in the hall, with her handbag in front of her in both hands, watching me with her basement face. But it was a different basement face. I could not have said how. I think, now, it was the face of a woman in a basement who has just heard the radio say the other words. *The white situation*. The face of a woman who does not yet believe them. "They're inside," she said.

I did not go in through the kitchen. I do not know why. I went back out, and round the side of the house, and up the three stone steps to the front door. And I stood there.

I did not knock. I stood on the step in the late light, with the canyon going gold behind me and the sea below, the grey-blue that goes almost black, and I could hear, through the door, very faintly, my son's voice. Counting.

He was counting something. I could not hear what. The numbers came through the wood, steady, flat, in order, one after another, the way I had counted tiles in a basement forty years ago and seconds between a siren and a sound.

*Four hundred and nine. Four hundred and ten. Four hundred and eleven.*

And I felt it.

I want to be honest, here, at the end, as I have tried to be everywhere. I felt the engine catch. I felt the old warm water. Standing on that step, with my son's voice coming through the door, I felt my mind begin to narrow, the world begin to go quiet around one thing, the lights going down in the cinema. I felt it reach for him. The way it had reached for the cube, and the board, and the firm, and the car, and the stone. The hook. Already.

My son.

I stood very still. I let it come. I did not know, standing there, whether this was the beginning of the most important season of my life or the beginning of the worst thing I would ever do to him. I did not know whether a person can be a season. Whether a man like me can point the engine at a child, and hold it there, and never let it narrow so far that the child becomes an interruption. Whether I could look at my son for the rest of my life and never once try to find the crack in him. Never once try to polish it out.

I did not know. I want to be honest. I did not know at all.

*We never stop wanting. We only learn to choose what we want.*

The counting stopped.

There were footsteps in the hall. Not Kaveh's. Lighter. Faster. Older.

The door opened.

Sahar was standing in it. She was taller than me now, or nearly. She was seventeen. Her hair was tied up with a pencil stuck through it. She was wearing my old university sweatshirt, the one that had been her mother's, the one the hospital had given back to my

mother in a plastic bag, washed now, soft, the sleeves pushed up to the elbows.

She did not say anything. She looked at me. At my face. At my empty hands. At the short flat end of my finger.

Behind her, at the end of the hall, by the window that looks down the canyon toward the sea, a boy was standing with his back to the glass. He was eleven. He had his mother's eyes and his hair stuck up at the back where he had slept on it, and he was holding a thick stack of exercise paper, taped together end to end, so long it trailed down onto the floor and across the carpet. Seven hundred and thirty squares. Every one with a neat cross in it. No number at the bottom.

He was looking at me. His lips had stopped moving.

I stood on the step.

I had brought nothing.

I had room.

My daughter stood in the door and looked at me, and waited, the way her mother had waited, the way Elias had waited, for weather, for light, for a stone to show where it wanted to open.

I did not know if she would let me in.

I did not know if I would stay.

I looked at her. Only at her. I did not look past her. I did not look for the crack.

And I lifted my foot from the step.

## GLOSSARY

**Baba** [baa-BAA] — Persian, *dad*. What Kian's children call him.

**Boart** [BORT] — The trade word for industrial diamonds of poor colour and shape, crushed into powder for saws, drills and the paste on a polishing wheel.

**Brilliance** — The white light a well-cut diamond sends back out of its top.

**Bruting** [BROO-ting] — Grinding one diamond against another to round its outline. The oldest part of the cutter's craft.

**Carat** [KA-rat] — The unit of a diamond's weight. One carat is a fifth of a gram, named after the carob seeds once used as weights in Middle Eastern and Mediterranean markets.

**Chehelom** [che-he-LOM] — Persian, *the fortieth*. The gathering held forty days after a death, which closes the first and hardest part of mourning.

**Cleaving** [KLEE-ving] — Splitting a diamond along its natural grain with one blow. The English word also means to hold on to someone tightly, as in the old marriage vows.

**Cloud** — A haze of tiny dots trapped inside a diamond, too small to see one by one.

**Crown** — The upper part of a cut diamond, above its widest edge.

**Culet** [KYOO-let] — The point at the very bottom of a cut diamond.

**Dead air** — Kian's name for the empty stretch after an obsession ends. A radio term for the silence when a station has nothing to broadcast.

**Dey** [DAY] — The tenth month of the Persian calendar, falling in the deep of winter, from late December to late January.

**Facet** [FA-set] — One flat, polished face of a cut stone. A round brilliant diamond has fifty-seven, or fifty-eight with a culet.

**Feather** — A small, flat crack inside a diamond, white and frayed at the edges like a feather frozen in ice.

**Fire** — The flashes of colour a cut diamond throws by splitting white light, the way a glass prism does.

**Frances Gerety** [GERR-uh-tee] — The American copywriter who wrote the slogan “A Diamond Is Forever” in 1947.

**Freetown** — The capital of Sierra Leone, on the Atlantic coast, founded as a home for freed slaves.

**Ganzfeld effect** [GANTS-felt] — German, *whole field*. The brain’s habit of inventing shapes, faces and places when the eyes see nothing but an even, unchanging field of light for a long time.

**Girdle** — The thin outer edge of a cut diamond, where the crown meets the pavilion.

**Gujarati** [goo-ja-RAA-tee] — The language of Gujarat, on the western coast of India, spoken by many families in the diamond trade.

**Haft-sin** [haft-SEEN] — Persian, *seven S’s*. The table laid for the Persian New Year with seven things whose names begin with the letter S.

**HPHT** — *High pressure, high temperature*. A machine that grows diamonds from carbon by squeezing and heating it as the deep earth does.

**Kimberley Process** [KIM-ber-lee] — The international scheme, begun in 2003, meant to keep diamonds that pay for rebel wars out of the trade. Named after the South African town where it was agreed.

**Kimberlite** [KIM-ber-lite] — The volcanic rock that carries diamonds up from about a hundred and fifty kilometres underground, named after Kimberley in South Africa.

**Koh-i-Noor** [KOH-ee-NOOR] — Persian, *mountain of light*. A great diamond fought over by kings for centuries, now in the British crown jewels.

**Kono** [KOH-noh] — A diamond-mining district in the east of Sierra Leone, and the place Elias was born.

**Lavoisier** [la-VWAH-zee-ay] — Antoine Lavoisier, the French chemist who burned a diamond in the 1770s and proved it was made of carbon.

**Loupe** [LOOP] — A small magnifying glass, usually ten times, held right up to the eye.

**Memorial diamond** — A diamond grown in a laboratory using carbon taken from a person's remains or hair.

**Motor-e kuchik** [mo-TOR-e koo-CHEEK] — Persian, *little engine*. Kian's mother's name for his mind.

**Needle** — A long, thin crystal of another mineral lying inside a diamond like a pin.

**Nader Shah** [naa-DER SHAAH] — The Persian king who took Delhi in 1739 and, by legend, named the Koh-i-Noor.

**Nowruz** [now-ROOZ] — Persian, *new day*. The Persian New Year, on the first day of spring.

**Octahedron** [ok-ta-HEE-dron] — Greek, *eight faces*. The shape a diamond most likes to grow in: two four-sided pyramids joined at their bases.

**Ordibehesht** [or-dee-be-HESHT] — The second month of the Persian calendar, from late April to late May.

**Pavilion** — The lower, cone-shaped part of a cut diamond, below its widest edge.

**Pinpoint** — A single tiny speck of light or dark inside a diamond.

**Retort** — The furnace chamber in which a body is cremated. The name comes from the glass vessel an alchemist heated over a flame.

**RUF** — The Revolutionary United Front, the rebel army in Sierra Leone's civil war from 1991 to 2002, known for cutting off civilians' hands.

**Scaife** [SKAYF] — The cutter's polishing wheel: a flat iron disc spinning about three thousand times a minute, coated with diamond dust and olive oil.

**Scintillation** [sin-ti-LAY-shun] — The sparkle of light and dark across a cut diamond as it, or the person looking at it, moves.

**Seasons** — Roxana's name for Kian's obsessions.

**Sierra Leone** [see-AIR-ah lee-OHN] — A small country on the Atlantic coast of West Africa.

**Star facets** — The eight small triangular faces around the table of a cut diamond.

**Table** — The large flat face on the top of a cut diamond, where the light comes in.

**Tolkowsky** [tol-KOV-skee] — Marcel Tolkowsky, the Antwerp-born engineer who worked out the ideal angles for a round diamond in 1919.

**Vaz'iyat-e ghermez** [vaz-ee-YAT-e gher-MEZ] — Persian, *the red situation*. The radio's name for an air-raid alert in wartime Tehran.

**Vaz'iyat-e sefid** [vaz-ee-YAT-e se-FEED] — Persian, *the white situation*. The radio's all-clear.

- ◆ Kian Sarrāf has always had an engine in him. Something catches his eye, the world goes quiet, and he does not come back until he has mastered it. His wife calls them his seasons. She writes them on the fridge.
- ◆ Then there is a curve on a mountain road, and the calendar stops.
- ◆ A laboratory can grow a diamond from what is left of a person. Kian decides that nobody will cut it but him. He leaves his children with his mother and goes to Antwerp, to the last hand-cutter on a street of armed guards and steel posts.
- ◆ The old man was born in the diamond fields of Sierra Leone. He has kept one stone uncut for twenty-eight years.
- ◆ For two years Kian learns to split, grind and polish the hardest thing on earth. He gives the wheel his nights, his fingertip, everything he has. And more than he knows.

*Every stone carries one tension.*

